

Hear All, See All, Say Nothing

Book One - Draft Reading Copy

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Large-print family reading edition

FRIDAY 20 SEPTEMBER 2019 - ARREST

CONNOR

Connor's last night outside did not feel like a last night.

That was the bit he would remember later.

Nothing announced itself.

There was no strange feeling in his stomach. No meaningful look at the front door. No sudden urge to ring his mum. No voice telling him to appreciate the sofa because, by breakfast, he might have absolutely no say over where he sat.

It was just a normal Friday night.

His normal, anyway.

There were four of them in the front room, shoes everywhere, music low enough not to start an argument with the neighbours and three different conversations happening at once. Reece was moaning about money. Someone else was telling a story Connor had already heard twice but was telling it with

such confidence that Connor almost admired him for trying again.

Connor lay across the corner of the sofa with one socked foot on the coffee table.

His phone buzzed beside him.

Not his normal phone.

The other one.

He glanced at the screen, read the message and put it face-down again.

"You gonna answer that?" Reece asked.

"In a minute."

"You said that ten minutes ago."

"Then I'll answer it in eleven."

Reece laughed and threw a cushion at him.

Connor caught it against his chest.

This was what being in control felt like to him then.

People came to his house. Phones went because people wanted something from him. Lads a couple of years younger listened when he spoke. Money arrived in little bursts.

Problems arrived too, but Connor had started mistaking having problems for being important.

He had been out most of the day working his cannabis line. Running about, answering phones, chasing people, sorting tiny dramas that felt enormous while he was inside them and completely pointless once he got home.

He told himself he did it for the right reasons.

His mum never had enough money. There was always something. Shoes. School stuff. A bill. One of his brothers wanting what everybody else seemed to get without thinking twice. Connor liked being the person who could produce twenty quid when twenty quid mattered. He liked turning up with something for his little brother and watching his face change.

That made the rest easier to explain to himself.

Not right.

Just explainable.

Tonight he was tired.

That was all.

The burglary was not a case in Connor's head anymore.

It was something he had done and then pushed backwards into that part of his memory where uncomfortable things went when nothing happened quickly enough to force him to face them.

Nobody had come for him.

No arrest. No knock. No dramatic phone call.

Days had become weeks, and Connor had gradually converted silence into proof that he had got away with it.

Every now and then the memory surfaced - the watches, the Mercedes, somebody's voice from that night - but he pushed it down again without much effort.

Tonight it was barely there at all.

He was thinking about weed, money, food and getting everyone out of his house so he could sleep.

He took the last pull of the joint, coughed once and immediately pretended he had not.

"Strong?" Reece said.

"Shut up."

Connor stubbed it into the ashtray, leaned forward and pulled off his trainers.

One landed properly.

The other fell on its side.

He wriggled his toes inside his socks.

"I'm done," he said. "No one's getting me back out tonight."

Someone laughed.

Then there was a vehicle door outside.

Another.

Connor looked towards the window.

Reece kept talking.

The shout came a second later.

"ARMED POLICE!"

Everything inside Connor stopped.

Not slowed.

Stopped.

The room that had felt warm and stupid and ordinary half a second earlier suddenly contained too many things.

Phones.

Smoke.

People.

The bag on the side.

The work phone.

The front door.

His bare feet.

"Oh, shit," somebody said.

Connor moved before he had properly decided to.

In blind panic he got the cannabis bag and work phone out of the room through the open window, less like somebody executing a plan and more like a person whose brain had reduced itself to a single useless instruction: not here.

Then the house filled with noise.

Commands.

Boots.

Someone telling everybody not to move.

Reece had both hands up before Connor did.

Connor noticed that and, absurdly, felt annoyed with him for being quicker.

"Hands where I can see them!"

Connor lifted his hands.

He had no shoes on.

That bothered him for some reason.

Of everything happening, his mind fixed on the fact that he had taken his trainers off about thirty seconds too early.

An officer moved him away from the window.

Another was speaking to the others.

Connor heard his own name.

Then the words:

"Aggravated burglary."

The burglary returned to him all at once.

Not as a memory anymore.

As a problem.

A real one.

They were not there because Connor had spent the day working his line.

They were there for the thing he had decided was finished simply because nobody had arrested him yet.

His stomach dropped.

For one stupid second his mind produced the thought:

How do they even know?

Then somebody said the words again and whatever private story he had been telling himself about getting away with it disappeared.

The journey to the police station happened in pieces.

Connor remembered the handcuffs more clearly than the roads.

He remembered trying to sit in a way that did not make him look frightened even though the

only people who could see him were police officers who had probably watched frightened men pretend not to be frightened for years.

He remembered thinking about his mum.

Then immediately deciding not to think about his mum.

Then thinking about her again.

Had they rung her?

Had somebody told her?

Would Reece tell everyone what had happened before Connor even reached the station?

Would the lads from the burglary know?

That last thought stayed.

The lads from the burglary.

Connor looked down at his cuffed hands.

Who else had been arrested?

Had someone spoken?

Had somebody been talking for weeks while Connor sat at home congratulating himself on getting away with it?

He had no way to know.

That was the beginning of the worst part.

Not knowing.

Police cells had too much time in them.

Connor discovered that within the first hour.

There was nothing useful to do except think,
and thinking had never been one of his
hobbies.

He sat on the hard bench with his elbows on
his knees and replayed the arrest until the
details began to feel unreal.

The shout.

The window.

Reece's hands going up.

The officer saying his name.

Aggravated burglary.

Now somebody else had said it out loud,
Connor could not stop thinking about it.

The watches.

The Mercedes.

Who knew what.

Whether somebody else had been arrested.

Whether somebody had spoken.

Whether there was evidence he had never even considered.

How long the police might have been looking at him while he carried on living as though nothing was happening.

Every possibility became evidence in his head.

Every silence became betrayal.

Every minute that passed made the case stronger.

He lay back.

Sat up.

Lay back again.

The light did not change enough to help him measure time.

At some point he tried to sleep.

His eyes closed.

The word came straight back.

Burglary.

He opened them again.

Yesterday Connor had thought the burglary was behind him.

By midnight it was the only thing in front of him.

SATURDAY 21 SEPTEMBER 2019

- CUSTODY

CONNOR

By morning Connor had decided three different people had grassed him up.

By breakfast he had decided none of them had.

By nine he was back to the first theory.

The cell did that to him.

It took a question and gave it enough silence to become six questions.

When the hatch opened, Connor sat up immediately.

"Solicitor."

For the first time since the arrest, a word sounded like it might belong to somebody on his side.

He stood too quickly.

His solicitor had the maddening calm of a man whose liberty was not currently being discussed.

Connor sat opposite him and tried to read the answer before the question had even been asked.

"What have they got?"

"Let's go through it properly."

Connor hated that sentence immediately.

Nobody said let's go through it properly before telling you something good.

The solicitor opened his notes.

"They recovered the Mercedes."

Connor nodded.

Cars got found.

That was not the sentence that frightened him.

The next one was.

"There's blood in the vehicle. They're saying it's yours."

Connor stared at him.

For a second, the words did not connect to anything.

"What blood?"

His solicitor looked at him.

Connor looked down at his hands.

And remembered.

His middle finger.

A cut he had noticed afterwards. Small enough to look at once, swear about and forget. He had never connected it to the burglary. Never thought about where he had been when it happened. Never imagined a tiny healed cut could still be waiting for him weeks later.

Connor rubbed the finger with his thumb even though there was almost nothing left to see.

"I cut my finger."

The solicitor watched him carefully.

"Right."

"I didn't even think-"

"Connor, listen. As things stand, they're treating that as strong evidence placing you in the recovered vehicle."

Connor looked up.

The solicitor did not soften it.

"You've basically been caught red-handed."

Connor hated how ordinary the phrase sounded.

Caught red-handed.

As though there were something almost funny about a forgotten cut being able to reach forward through time and grab hold of the rest of his life.

Until then there had still been little escape routes in Connor's head.

Maybe somebody had talked.

Maybe police were fishing.

Maybe they had the wrong end of something and his solicitor would find the hole in it.

The blood did not feel like a hole.

It felt like a door closing.

The solicitor turned a page.

"There's another issue. Witnesses say a firearm was present."

Connor stopped rubbing his finger.

"They ain't found one."

"I know."

"So there isn't one."

The solicitor gave him a look Connor was beginning to recognise from professionals.

Not agreement.

Not disagreement.

Just a look that meant the world was more complicated than the answer Connor wanted.

"They haven't recovered one," he said. "That doesn't make the allegation disappear."

Connor stared at the wall behind him.

"I'm not admitting no gun."

"I'm not asking you to. I'm telling you what the allegation is."

A burglary was already bad enough in Connor's head.

Add a gun and the word changed shape.

It became heavier. More adult. More like something you heard on the news and assumed had been done by somebody who knew exactly what sort of trouble they were in.

Connor had not known.

Or perhaps he had known and simply refused to look at it properly until now.

"How long?" he asked.

"We're nowhere near sentence yet."

"Yeah, but how long could I get?"

"Connor-"

"Worst case."

The solicitor paused.

That pause alone added years in Connor's head.

"You're getting ahead of yourself."

Which was not an answer, so Connor supplied one.

Ten years.

Maybe twelve.

Fifteen.

Once fifteen entered his head, it refused to leave.

He was twenty-one.

Fifteen years was almost everything he could properly remember living, lived again behind a door.

His mum fifteen years older.

His brothers grown men.

His sister with a life he knew nothing about.

His little brother not little anymore.

That one hurt the most.

He tried to calculate how old his little brother would be.

Stopped halfway.

His girlfriend would wait, he told himself.

His family would visit.

Everything would still be there.

He needed to believe that because the alternative was too large to fit inside the room.

"Connor."

He looked up.

"We deal with what is actually in front of us. Not fifteen imaginary years."

Connor nodded.

Then spent the rest of the morning thinking about fifteen imaginary years.

The detective in interview did not help.

He had a folder in front of him that Connor immediately decided was too thick.

No folder needed to be that thick unless your life was about to become extremely inconvenient.

The recorder started.

Names were stated.

Formal words filled the room.

Connor sat beside his solicitor and tried to look like somebody who had done this many times before.

He had not.

The detective knew it.

Connor could tell.

"You understand the seriousness of what you're facing?"

Connor looked at his solicitor.

"You can answer whether you understand the question," the solicitor said.

"Yeah."

"Do you?" the detective asked.

Connor disliked him immediately.

Not because he was shouting. He wasn't.

That would almost have been easier.

He spoke calmly, as though the worst possible version of Connor's future had already been agreed by everyone except Connor.

He talked about the burglary.

The watches.

The recovered Mercedes.

The blood.

Then the witnesses.

"More than one person says a gun was present."

Connor said nothing.

"That's where this changes, Connor. That's where you crossed the line."

Connor stared at a scratch on the table.

"Was there a firearm?"

Connor swallowed.

"No comment."

"Who else was with you?"

"No comment."

"Who took the watches?"

"No comment."

"Who drove the Mercedes away?"

"No comment."

The phrase started sounding less like English after a while.

No comment.

No comment.

No comment.

It became the only part of the room Connor could control.

The detective sat back.

"Your blood is in the car. You're the person we've got. Think carefully about how much of your life you're prepared to lose protecting people who aren't sitting in this room."

Connor kept looking at the scratch.

For a moment he saw his mum instead.

Then his brothers.

Then the lads who had been there that night.

Fear made every exit look like an exit.

Even when you had no idea where it led.

Connor lifted his eyes.

"No comment."

The interview ended without Connor feeling that anything had ended.

Back in the cell he began measuring his future in numbers.

Ten.

Twelve.

Fifteen.

Then five, because five sounded better.

Then fifteen again because his brain had apparently decided hope was suspicious.

He wondered who knew he had been arrested.

His mum definitely.

His girlfriend probably.

The lads, almost certainly.

He wondered whether the co-offenders were asleep in their own beds.

The thought made him angry.

Then ashamed of being angry.

He had chosen not to give names.

That choice meant something to him.

He wanted it to mean he was loyal.

Sitting alone in a police cell, loyalty felt less glamorous than it had outside.

It felt like a door he had deliberately left shut while somebody else held the key.

A custody officer brought food Connor barely touched.

Later someone asked if he wanted anything.

"Yeah," Connor said. "To know what's happening."

The officer looked at him for half a second.

"Join the club."

The hatch shut.

Connor nearly laughed.

Instead he lay back and stared at the ceiling.

He had always thought the frightening part of getting caught would be police arriving.

He had been wrong.

The frightening part was everything after they stopped shouting.

SUNDAY 22 SEPTEMBER 2019 - WAITING

CONNOR

Sunday was worse because almost nothing happened.

Connor would not have believed that on Friday night.

On Friday, armed police had been the worst thing that could happen.

On Saturday, the blood was the worst thing that could happen.

By Sunday, the worst thing was a closed door and no information.

He woke without knowing properly whether he had slept.

The light was the same.

The walls were the same.

His clothes felt stale.

Somewhere beyond the door, people moved through a normal working day that Connor could hear but not see.

Keys.

Footsteps.

A hatch.

A voice.

Silence.

He had never realised how much of ordinary life was choosing what happened next.

Get up or stay in bed.

Make tea or don't.

Go out or stay home.

Answer the phone or leave it ringing.

Tiny choices that did not feel like choices until somebody took all of them away.

Now Connor waited to be told when he could stand somewhere else.

He thought about his mum first.

He tried not to.

That did not work.

She would be angry.

Scared too, probably, but Connor preferred imagining the anger because anger was easier.

His mum angry meant his mum was still his mum.

She would ask why.

Not why did the police arrest you?

Why had he done any of it?

Connor had answers ready for that question.

Money.

The kids.

Helping out.

Not wanting her doing everything herself.

The answers had sounded solid outside.

Inside the cell they sounded different.

He could not help anybody from here.

Could not give his little brother money.

Could not take his sister anywhere.

Could not sort a bill.

Could not even ring home when he wanted.

For the first time Connor saw the contradiction without being able to look away from it.

He had spent years telling himself he was becoming the person his family could rely on.

Two days in custody had made him the least useful person in the family.

He rolled onto his side.

That thought could do one.

So he thought about his girlfriend instead.

That was not much better.

She would wait.

Obviously.

People's girlfriends waited all the time.

Five years, ten years, whatever. People did it.

Connor had seen pictures online. Visits.

Couples staying together.

His brain supplied fifteen again.

He shut it down.

She would wait.

His family would visit.

His mates would put money on his account.

His little brother would still be his little brother.

Everything outside would simply pause until he got back.

That was the story Connor needed on Sunday.

He did not yet understand that nothing outside had agreed to pause for him.

At some point food arrived.

Connor looked at it.

Then at the hatch.

"What happens tomorrow?"

The officer on the other side looked back.

"You'll be told."

"Yeah, but court?"

"You'll be told."

"Am I getting bail?"

The officer gave him a look that suggested Connor had confused him with a judge.

"Eat your food."

The hatch closed.

Connor sat down.

"Cheers for that," he muttered.

He ate anyway.

The co-offenders came back into his head in waves.

He imagined them everywhere except where he was.

One eating breakfast.

One driving somewhere.

One telling people Connor was the only one nicked.

Maybe none of that was true.

It did not matter.

Prison had not even started yet and Connor's imagination was already producing rumours faster than anybody else could.

He wondered whether he had done the right thing in interview.

No comment.

No names.

At the time it had felt like the only version of himself he could still control.

Now the detective's sentence returned:

They're not sitting in this room with you.

Connor hated him for being right about that one detail.

He imagined talking.

Then imagined what that would make him.

Then hated himself for even imagining it.

"Fuck's sake," he said to nobody.

A voice from somewhere beyond the wall shouted something he could not make out.

Connor sat up as if it might be relevant to him.

It wasn't.

That happened a lot.

Later, fifteen years returned properly.

He tried to make it real.

Twenty-one now.

Thirty-six when he got out.

Thirty-six sounded ancient to Connor.

He knew, objectively, that it was not.

That did not help.

He pictured his mum at whatever age she would be then.

His sister.

His brothers.

Then his little brother.

Connor started doing the maths.

Stopped.

He actually sat up to stop himself.

"Nah."

He did not want the answer.

That frightened him more than the number fifteen itself.

There were things Connor normally attacked by knowing more.

Who owed money.

Who had said what.

Where somebody was.

What needed sorting.

Now he had found a question he actively did not want answered.

How old would everyone be when he came home?

He lay back.

The ceiling offered nothing.

Sunday evening arrived without looking different from Sunday afternoon.

Connor had no watch.

He had begun estimating time by meals, footsteps and how annoyed he felt.

He was very annoyed, so it was probably late.

He thought about the house.

His trainers still on the floor.

That image got him unexpectedly.

Not police.

Not court.

His trainers.

One upright.

One on its side.

He had taken them off because he was done
for the night.

The arrogance of that now seemed almost
funny.

No one's getting me back out tonight.

Connor covered his face with both hands.

A laugh escaped before he could stop it.

It did not sound happy.

He wondered who had moved the trainers.

Maybe his mum.

Maybe police.

Maybe they were still exactly where he had left them.

He would have given a ridiculous amount of money to be annoyed about something that small again.

Before trying to sleep, Connor made himself a deal.

Tomorrow would be better because tomorrow something would happen.

Court meant answers.

A judge meant a decision.

Maybe bail.

Maybe home.

Maybe his solicitor would explain the blood away somehow.

Maybe the firearm allegation would fall apart.

Maybe everything would shrink back down into something manageable.

He knew enough to understand that some of those hopes contradicted what he had been told.

He believed them anyway.

Hope did not need to be sensible when it was all you had left to do.

Connor turned onto his side.

Tomorrow, he told himself.

Tomorrow he would know what was happening.

He was wrong about that too.

MONDAY 23 SEPTEMBER 2019 - COURT / LEWES

CONNOR

Court moved quickly once the important bit arrived.

Before that there was waiting.

Waiting in a cell.

Waiting for a solicitor.

Waiting for a barrister Connor had met for approximately six minutes to discuss decisions capable of swallowing his twenties.

Waiting to be called.

Waiting while people spoke about him in a language that was technically English but seemed designed to make defendants feel like guests at their own lives.

Connor listened for only two things.

Bail.

Home.

Everything else went past him.

His barrister explained something about the seriousness of the allegation, the evidence, the fact that Connor had been identified by blood and the concerns surrounding the alleged firearm.

Connor nodded at the correct moments.

"But I can get bail, yeah?"

The barrister paused.

"We're making the application."

Connor heard:

Probably.

That was not what had been said.

It was what Connor needed to hear.

When he was finally brought into court, the room was less dramatic than he expected.

That somehow made it worse.

Connor had imagined something from television. Big speeches. Somebody slamming something onto a desk. A moment when

everyone looked at him and the future was announced.

Instead there were papers.

People turning pages.

Professionals speaking in calm voices.

His name sounded different when strangers used his full name.

Connor Blake.

As if Connor Blake were somebody being discussed rather than him.

He looked towards his barrister whenever he heard a phrase he did not understand.

The barrister occasionally gave him a tiny nod that explained nothing.

Then the word arrived.

Remanded.

Connor looked at him.

He knew what it meant.

He just wanted it to mean something else this time.

"So I'm not going home?" he whispered when he got the chance.

"Not today."

Not today.

Such a small sentence.

It broke something enormous.

Until that moment Connor had preserved a private version of events where all of this was temporary.

Police station temporary.

Court temporary.

Handcuffs temporary.

Someone would eventually open a door and he would walk back into his life.

Instead he was taken downstairs.

A door closed behind him.

Home continued without him.

The prison van had tiny windows.

Connor decided that was crueller than having no windows at all.

No windows would have allowed him to imagine there was nothing outside.

The little pane gave him glimpses.

A petrol station.

A row of houses.

A bloke walking a dog.

Traffic lights.

People carrying shopping.

Normal life appeared in fragments and vanished again.

At one point they passed somewhere Connor recognised.

He leaned toward the small window.

For a few seconds he knew exactly where he was.

He could have told the driver which lane moved quicker.

Knew where the nearest chicken shop was.

Knew which pub had a pool table.

Knew somebody who lived three streets over.

None of that knowledge was useful anymore.

The van kept moving.

Connor sat back.

He thought about his mum.

He thought about whether she had slept.

He thought about his brothers and sister and all the stupid little things he had spent money on for them because buying things had always been easier than explaining why he was never around enough.

Then his little brother.

Fifteen tried to come back.

Connor refused the maths again.

His girlfriend would wait.

His family would visit.

Everything would still be there.

He repeated those facts until they sounded almost convincing.

Lewes did not appear like a revelation.

One minute the van was moving through ordinary streets.

Then the prison was simply there.

Old walls.

Flint, brick, stone, height.

The sort of place that looked as if it had been built before anybody had thought prisoners might need cheering up.

Connor stared through the little window.

"Fuck me," somebody somewhere in the van said.

Connor did not know who.

He agreed with him.

Films had given Connor the wrong idea about prison.

He had expected something clean and modern and obviously institutional.

Lewes looked older than his fear.

Generations of men had arrived there not wanting to go in.

That thought was supposed to make his situation feel less unique.

It did not.

The gate took them.

The outside disappeared.

MASON

Mason could normally tell a first-timer before the first-timer opened his mouth.

There was a particular way they looked at everything.

Not staring exactly.

Trying not to stare.

Trying to absorb the room without letting the room know they needed to absorb it.

The young one coming through reception had it badly.

Twenty-one, Mason guessed.

Maybe twenty-two.

Property held too close to his body. Eyes going everywhere. Face arranged into something he probably thought was neutral.

Mason had seen the expression on hundreds of men.

I am absolutely fine and would like everybody to stop noticing how absolutely fine I am.

The lad looked at one of the prisoner orderlies as if the man might eat him.

Mason almost smiled.

The orderly in question was mostly worried about whether he would get his tea before it went cold.

That was prison for you.

Terror and boredom sharing the same room and never agreeing which one was more important.

Then Mason noticed the other arrival.

He stopped smiling.

Not because the man did anything.

That was the point.

Craig came in without the first-timer's eyes.

No need to learn how a prison reception worked.

No need to guess which door meant what.

He had arrived from another establishment, moved after security concerns that nobody on Mason's level needed explained in detail.

The paperwork would know more than the wing did.

The wing would invent the rest by dinner.

Mason knew the name.

More importantly, he knew other people knew the name.

The room changed by degrees.

A peer worker glanced over and glanced away too quickly.

Another prisoner went quiet halfway through a sentence.

One officer checked a sheet twice.

Craig did nothing to encourage any of it.

The young first-timer noticed the noticing.

Of course he did.

He had no idea what it meant.

Mason watched him look from face to face.

That was almost worse than knowing.

CONNOR

Reception was a collection of things Connor had never expected to care about.

Where to stand.

Where to put property.

When he could speak.

Whether he had heard an instruction properly.

Whether asking someone to repeat it would make him look stupid.

A female officer stood in front of him with the sort of presence that made Connor straighten without deciding to.

"Look at me when I'm speaking to you."

Connor had been looking over her shoulder.

"I am."

"You're not. You're looking everywhere except at me."

Connor looked at her.

"There you go. Wasn't difficult."

He felt sixteen.

Behind her were two prisoner workers who looked enormous to him.

One had arms Connor immediately decided were unnecessary for any job involving forms.

The other had a face that looked permanently unimpressed.

Connor kept stealing glances at them.

Neither appeared particularly interested in Connor.

That somehow made them more intimidating.

"First time?" one of them asked eventually.

Connor considered lying.

There seemed no useful version of the lie.

"Yeah."

"Can tell."

"How?"

The man looked at Connor's property, his face, the way he was standing.

"Everything."

Connor decided he did not like him.

The man smiled.

"You'll calm down."

That was worse.

Connor first saw Craig properly in a holding area.

Not because somebody pointed him out.

Because people kept not pointing him out.

There was a man sitting several places away who looked, to Connor, surprisingly normal.

Not massive.

Not shouting.

Not surrounded by people performing respect.

Yet attention kept bending towards him.

A glance from one prisoner.

A pause in another conversation.

Somebody saying something quietly to someone else.

Connor watched until Craig looked over.

Connor immediately looked away.

That annoyed him.

He looked back on principle.

Craig was no longer looking at him.

Connor felt as if he had lost an argument
Craig did not know they were having.

A lad sitting near Connor leaned slightly
towards another prisoner.

"That's him."

"Who?"

The second prisoner gave him a look.

"Craig."

The name meant nothing to Connor.

He waited for more.

None came.

Then from somewhere behind him, quiet but clear:

"Craig's here."

The phrase moved through the room without anybody officially repeating it.

Connor looked at Craig again.

He still looked like a bloke sitting in a prison holding area.

That was Connor's first lesson in reputation.

Sometimes the most frightening thing about a man was everybody else.

OFFICER MERCER

Officer Mercer had seen names become bigger than people before.

She disliked it.

It made risk harder, not easier.

A famous name arrived and suddenly half the prison behaved as if they had received personal invitations to take an interest.

Craig's transfer paperwork mattered to Mercer.

The whispered versions did not.

Security move.

Serious case.

Interest from other prisoners.

Fine.

Those were things she could work with.

He's a legend.

He's dangerous.

He knows everyone.

He owns half of Sussex.

Those were stories.

Stories made men stupid.

She watched Craig answer a question without attitude.

Then watched the young prisoner two seats away pretending not to watch Craig.

"Blake," she called.

The young lad looked round too quickly.

"Yeah?"

"You'll get used to answering without looking guilty every time somebody says your name."

A few prisoners laughed.

Connor went red.

Mercer almost felt bad.

Almost.

CONNOR

By the time Connor reached G Wing, his head was full.

Names he did not know.

Instructions he had already forgotten.

Doors.

Keys.

His mum.

The blood.

The gun allegation.

The word remanded.

And Craig.

Mostly, if Connor was being truthful, Craig because everybody else seemed to care so much.

He carried his things where he was told.

Somebody farther along the wing said the name again.

Craig.

Another voice answered.

Connor could not hear the words.

He looked through the movement of bodies and caught sight of Craig being directed elsewhere on the wing.

For a second Craig glanced back.

Connor did not look away this time.

Then a door shut between them.

Connor stood with his property in his arms, still not understanding what exactly had arrived at Lewes with him.

By morning, he would begin finding out.

TUESDAY 24 SEPTEMBER 2019 - THE NAME

MASON - M WING / INDUCTION

Mason knew the first morning was when prison became real.

Arrival had too much movement in it.

Reception. Questions. Property. Doors. People telling you where to stand.

The first morning was different.

You woke up and realised the building had not disappeared during the night.

The new lad, Connor Blake, had the face for it.

Mason saw him during induction movement looking as if he had slept for twelve minutes and spent eleven of them arguing with himself.

"Morning," Mason said.

Connor looked at him suspiciously.

"Is it?"

Mason smiled.

"Good. Sarcasm survived the night. That's something."

Connor looked around.

"How long you been here?"

"This time?"

Connor paused.

Mason enjoyed the pause.

"That bad, yeah?"

"Depends who you ask."

"I'm asking you."

"Then yes."

Connor half laughed.

Mason liked him more for that.

He had seen young men arrive trying so hard to look dangerous that they forgot to look human.

Connor was frightened, but at least he had not yet turned fear into theatre.

Not completely.

Mason glanced across the area.

Craig was there too.

Different morning entirely.

Craig looked as though prison had simply changed address.

That difference was not lost on anybody.

Especially Connor.

"You know him?" Connor asked quietly.

Mason looked at him.

"Who?"

Connor nodded almost imperceptibly towards Craig.

"Him."

"You asking because you want to know, or because everybody else wants to know?"

Connor frowned.

"Both."

"At least you're honest."

Mason picked up what he was carrying.

"You'll hear plenty."

"That's not an answer."

"It's prison. You'll get used to those."

He left Connor with that.

There was no point giving the lad every answer on day two.

Prison would provide enough of its own.

OFFICER MERCER

Mercer hated mornings after a notable arrival.

Everyone became an expert overnight.

A prisoner who had never met Craig knew his entire criminal history by breakfast.

Another had apparently been at school with his cousin.

A third had heard that somebody's brother's mate had once worked for him.

By lunch somebody would probably remember being present at his birth.

Mercer dealt in what she could verify.

Craig had been transferred in.

There were security concerns.

There was unusual prisoner interest.

That was enough.

She found Connor standing where he had been told to stand but somehow managing to look as though he had been placed there by accident.

"Blake."

He looked over.

Less guilty than yesterday.

Progress.

"Sleep?"

"Bit."

"Bit isn't a unit of time."

"Felt like one in there."

Mercer almost smiled.

"You'll settle."

Connor looked unconvinced.

Then his eyes drifted past her.

Craig again.

"You keep looking at him," Mercer said.

Connor snapped his attention back.

"I don't."

"You just did."

"Everyone does."

"That's not a defence."

"Didn't know I needed one."

There it was.

A bit of the outside Connor returning.

Mercer preferred that to the pale boy from reception.

"Whatever you've heard," she said,
"remember most people in here improve
stories every time they repeat them."

Connor nodded.

"So he's not important?"

Mercer looked at him.

"I didn't say that either."

Connor smiled despite himself.

"You lot love doing that."

"Doing what?"

"Answering without answering."

"You'll fit right in."

She moved on.

CONNOR

The first proper phone call home made prison more real than the gate had.

Connor had spent all morning wanting it.

Then when he got the chance, he stood with the receiver and suddenly did not know what to say.

His mum answered.

"Hello?"

Connor closed his eyes.

"Mum."

Silence.

Not long.

Just long enough.

"You all right?"

It was the wrong question.

Of course he was not all right.

But Connor heard the strain in her voice and answered automatically.

"Yeah."

"Don't lie to me."

That nearly broke him.

He looked along the wing instead.

Men walking. Someone laughing. Someone shouting for an officer. A television somewhere too loud.

"I'm all right," he said again, quieter.

"What happened?"

"Can't really talk about it."

"They said burglary."

Connor swallowed.

"Yeah."

"Connor."

One word.

His whole childhood inside it.

"I know."

She asked about court.

He explained badly.

She asked how long he would be there.

He did not know.

She asked what he needed.

He did not know that either.

Then his little brother came on.

That was worse.

"Where are you?"

Connor looked at the wall.

"I'm away for a bit."

"Mum said prison."

Connor gave a small laugh because there was nothing else available.

"Yeah. Prison."

"Did you do something bad?"

Connor looked down.

"I'll talk to you about it when I see you."

"When?"

Another question with no answer.

Connor hated prison for making him useless at questions.

"Soon."

He said it confidently enough that his little brother accepted it.

Connor did not.

When the call ended he stayed still for a second too long.

"You done?"

Somebody behind him asked.

Connor handed the phone over.

"Yeah."

He walked away before his face could do anything embarrassing.

Later Craig was sitting near him.

Not with him.

Near him.

Connor was becoming aware that the difference mattered.

He had heard the name three more times since breakfast.

One version said Craig controlled half of Sussex.

Another said London.

Another said both, which seemed greedy.

Connor looked over.

Craig noticed.

"You all right?"

Connor felt caught.

"Yeah."

"Good."

Craig went back to what he was doing.

Connor waited.

Nothing else came.

"Everyone knows you," Connor said.

Craig looked up again.

"Apparently."

"You don't sound surprised."

"Would you prefer I was?"

Connor shrugged.

"People keep saying stuff."

"People get bored."

"One bloke said you own half of Sussex."

Craig considered that.

"Which half?"

Connor laughed before he could stop himself.

Craig's face barely changed.

"Important distinction."

"You're taking the piss."

"A little."

This was not what Connor expected.

He had imagined that somebody with that sort of reputation would speak differently.

Louder perhaps.

More threatening.

Craig sounded like a man discussing weather.

"Why'd you come here?" Connor asked.

Craig looked at him for a beat.

"Moved."

"From where?"

"Another prison."

"Why?"

"You always ask this many questions?"

"Probably."

"That'll be tiring for both of us."

Connor grinned.

He noticed Craig had answered without answering.

Maybe Mercer was right.

He was fitting in.

MALIK

By lunchtime Malik had heard Craig was at Lewes from four different people.

That was not unusual.

What was unusual was who the four people were.

One man from C.

One from A.

Somebody who barely spoke to either of them.

And a message from outside asking the same question in a different form.

Is it true?

Malik did not answer immediately.

Information was only valuable before everybody had it.

He listened instead.

Craig had been moved.

Security transfer.

Trouble at the last place.

No, not trouble. Something bigger.

No, nothing happened there at all.

He had asked to move.

He had been forced to move.

He had enemies.

He had friends everywhere.

Malik discarded most of it.

Then somebody mentioned another name.

Not loudly.

Almost as a joke.

Big Sharky.

Malik's attention sharpened.

"What about him?"

The man shrugged.

"Nothing. Just saying."

People loved saying just saying immediately after saying something they very much wanted repeated.

Malik smiled.

"Then I'm just listening."

He walked away.

For the first time, Craig being at Lewes felt less like gossip and more like the beginning of something.

WEDNESDAY 25 SEPTEMBER 2019 - THE MESSAGE

PHONE CALL

The call lasted less than two minutes.

The man on one end did most of the talking.

"He's there."

A pause.

"Lewes."

Another pause.

"Yeah. Moved in Monday."

The voice on the other end was calm.

"You sure?"

"Hundred percent."

Silence.

The man with the phone waited.

Then the other voice said:

"All right."

Nothing dramatic.

No shouting.

No speech.

The calm made the man holding the phone more nervous than anger would have.

"You want me to-"

"No."

The word stopped him.

Then:

"People will hear."

The call ended.

By the afternoon, people had.

JINX - A WING

Jinx hated money when it arrived attached to somebody else's problem.

Free money did not exist in prison.

There was money you earned.

Money you owed.

Money somebody wanted back.

And money that came with consequences the person offering it would not be around to serve.

Rico was grinning.

That was already a bad sign.

"What?" Jinx said.

"Nothing."

"You look like you've discovered investing."

Rico laughed.

"You heard?"

Jinx had.

Several versions.

Enough money to be serious.

Not enough detail to be sensible.

Craig.

That was all anybody needed to attach the rest of the story themselves.

"I heard people chatting," Jinx said.

"That's not what I asked."

"Then ask somebody who works in customer service."

Rico grinned again.

Jinx did not.

"Don't get excited."

"I'm not."

"Your face is excited."

"My face is naturally optimistic."

"Your face is naturally stupid."

Rico laughed.

Then lowered his voice.

"It's real though."

Jinx looked at him.

"According to who?"

Rico gave the smallest shrug.

Outside.

That was enough.

Jinx looked away.

People outside loved talking about what people inside should do.

They did not lose association.

They did not get moved.

They did not add time, trouble, enemies or years of tension to a sentence because somebody else had decided a feud needed feeding.

"Whatever you heard," Jinx said, "leave it alone."

Rico's grin faded slightly.

"I didn't say I was doing anything."

"Good."

"I'm just saying."

"That's how prison starts most bad ideas."

Rico rolled his eyes.

Jinx let him.

He knew the problem was not Rico alone.

Once money entered a wing, it became everybody's imagination.

CONNOR - G WING

Connor spent most of Wednesday thinking about a completely different problem.

His girlfriend had not answered when he expected her to.

That was it.

That was the crisis.

Around him, names and money and Craig travelled through conversations he did not understand.

Connor was worried about why a phone had rung out.

He tried again later.

Nothing.

"Probably busy," somebody said.

Connor looked at him.

"Didn't ask."

"You looked like you were asking the wall."

Connor walked away.

She was probably busy.

Work.

Family.

Anything.

He was not going to become one of those men who panicked because somebody outside did not answer immediately.

He lasted eleven minutes before trying again.

Still nothing.

Craig passed nearby.

"Problem?"

"No."

Craig looked at the phone.

Then Connor.

"Looks very much like a problem."

"Girlfriend ain't answering."

Craig nodded once.

"And?"

Connor frowned.

"What do you mean, and?"

"You want me to ring her?"

Connor laughed despite himself.

"No."

"Good. Be weird."

Craig carried on.

Connor watched him go.

He still knew almost nothing about the man.

Yet prison already seemed to bend conversations around him.

Connor tried the phone one more time.

This time she answered.

"Where have you been?" he said.

"Hello to you too."

Relief arrived so fast Connor turned it into irritation.

"I've been ringing."

"I was busy."

"Doing what?"

A pause.

"Connor."

He heard himself.

He hated that he heard himself.

"Forget it."

"How are you?"

He looked around G Wing.

"Fine."

Another lie for somebody outside.

Prison was filling up with them.

OFFICER BENNETT

Officer Bennett read the message twice before deleting it.

Then wished he had not deleted it because now he could not check whether it had really said what he thought it said.

He knew it had.

That was not the point.

The point was wanting it to disappear.

His shift had started normally.

That was becoming one of the things he hated most.

People said good morning.

Someone complained about staffing.

A kettle boiled.

A prisoner argued about an application.

Normality carried on around a problem that no longer felt normal at all.

The message had been simple.

A reminder.

Not a threat exactly.

Those were worse sometimes.

Threats at least admitted what they were.

This had the tone of somebody reminding Bennett about an appointment.

He put the phone away before entering work.

Inside, he told himself the same thing he had been telling himself for weeks.

One thing.

Then finished.

That was all.

He would deal with one thing and the pressure would stop.

He already knew that was a lie.

He kept using it anyway.

Later Mercer asked him if he was all right.

"Fine."

"You look tired."

"Got a kid. That's the uniform."

She accepted the joke.

Bennett was grateful.

He was beginning to understand how easy it was to hide panic inside an ordinary working day.

MALIK - C WING

The figure changed three times before lunch.

Malik heard one amount at breakfast.

A bigger one before midday.

By afternoon somebody had doubled it again because apparently prison inflation operated faster than the economy outside.

He did not care about the number.

He cared that people who normally had no reason to agree were all saying there was a number.

That was different.

Rumour usually spread like smoke.

This had direction.

"You reckon it's Sharky?" someone asked him.

Malik gave him a blank look.

"Why are you asking me?"

"You know things."

"That's a rumour too."

The man laughed.

Malik did not.

He had heard Big Sharky's name twice now.

Once could be somebody trying to sound informed.

Twice might still be that.

Three times was when Malik started listening properly.

He looked across C Wing.

Craig was not there yet.

Still G.

But people on C were already discussing where he would land.

That told Malik almost as much as the money did.

Reputation travelled ahead of allocation.

JINX - A WING

By evening Rico had stopped grinning.

Jinx noticed.

"What now?"

"Nothing."

"You're terrible at nothing."

Rico sat down.

"People are serious."

"People are always serious after somebody else offers money."

"You don't get it."

Jinx looked at him.

"Then explain it without saying anything stupid."

Rico opened his mouth.

Closed it.

That was more worrying than whatever he might have said.

Jinx leaned back.

"Listen to me. People outside can say whatever they want. They sleep in their own beds after."

Rico looked away.

"I know."

"Do you?"

No answer.

Jinx watched him.

The problem with being the sensible one was that everybody assumed sensible meant safe.

It did not.

It just meant you saw trouble earlier.

THURSDAY 26 SEPTEMBER 2019 - C WING

CONNOR

Connor had been in Lewes three days when somebody told him he was moving.

He had just started learning where things were on G Wing.

He even knew where the showers were.

That felt like progress.

Then an officer told him to get his things together.

"Where am I going?"

"C."

Connor waited for more.

None came.

Prison staff had a gift for making information sound like it should already mean something to you.

"Is that good?"

The officer looked at him.

"It's a wing, Blake."

Connor decided that was not an answer.

Again.

He gathered his property.

Craig was moving too.

That fact reached Connor before Craig did.

"Both of you C," somebody said.

Connor looked over.

Craig caught the look.

"Stop smiling," Craig said.

"I'm not smiling."

"You look pleased."

"Just nice knowing someone."

"You've known me three days."

"That's about fifteen years in here."

Craig almost smiled.

"You'll be running the place by Christmas."

Connor grinned.

He had no idea how much trouble there was in believing jokes like that.

C Wing sounded different before Connor even properly saw it.

More voices.

More movement.

More of the constant layered noise he was beginning to associate with prison.

G Wing had still felt temporary.

People arriving. People asking questions. People looking confused.

C felt established.

Everyone seemed to know where they were going except Connor.

He carried his bags onto the wing and immediately became aware of eyes.

Fresh face.

Property.

New arrival.

Men looked because there was nothing unusual about looking.

Connor experienced every glance as an assessment.

He tried walking as if he had done it a hundred times.

Then the alarm went.

The whole atmosphere changed so quickly Connor nearly stopped moving.

Officers ran.

Doors opened.

Voices sharpened.

Men who had been talking normally a second earlier moved aside without needing to be told twice.

Connor stood with his bags and watched staff disappear toward the shower area.

"Keep moving," an officer told him.

Connor did not.

Not immediately.

A prisoner was brought out a short while later for treatment, holding the side of his face.

In the confusion Connor thought the sight was far worse than it later proved to be.

That did not matter in the moment.

His stomach tightened.

He had been on the main wing for minutes.

Someone beside him looked over, then went back to complaining about canteen as if nothing had happened.

Connor stared at him.

"What?" the man said.

"Nothing."

"You new?"

"Yeah."

"Can tell."

Connor was already sick of that sentence.

The alarm stopped.

The wing noise gradually returned.

Not all at once.

Just enough to make Connor realise everybody else had learned how to put frightening things into a box and carry on talking.

G Wing had been prison with stabilisers on.

C Wing had just taken them off.

OFFICER MERCER

Mercer saw Connor standing with his property after the alarm and recognised the look immediately.

He had just discovered that prison could switch moods faster than he could.

"Blake."

Connor looked over.

"You all right?"

"Yeah."

"That answer's doing a lot of work this week."

Connor looked back toward where the injured prisoner had been taken.

"Is he all right?"

"He's being dealt with."

"Looked bad."

"Things sometimes look worse in the first few seconds."

Connor nodded.

Mercer could see him filing that away as if it were advice.

"Don't decide what the whole prison is from one incident," she added.

Connor gave her a look.

"Bit late."

"You've been here three days. Everything's a bit late to you."

He smiled despite himself.

Mercer pointed down the landing.

"Get your cell sorted."

Connor adjusted his bags.

"Where's Craig?"

Mercer stared at him.

Connor sighed.

"Forget I asked."

"Good idea."

He walked off.

Mercer watched him go.

Three days and already orbiting somebody else's problem.

Young men could be impressively efficient.

CONNOR

The officer checked the name on his sheet.

"Connor Blake?"

"Yeah."

He pointed into the cell.

"You're in here."

Connor stepped through with his bags.

There was already somebody inside.

A lad roughly his age, maybe slightly older, lying on the bottom bunk with the confidence of someone who had decided the cell belonged to him months ago.

He looked up.

"You Blake?"

Connor looked back toward the officer disappearing down the landing.

"Apparently."

"I gathered that. He just announced you."

Connor laughed.

The lad sat up.

"Jamie. Everyone calls me Jamo."

"Connor."

Jamo looked at the bags.

"First sentence?"

"First time in jail."

Jamo nodded slowly, enjoying the information.

"Yeah. Could tell."

Connor dropped his property onto the spare bunk.

"If one more person says that to me-"

"What you gonna do?"

Connor looked at him.

Jamo grinned.

"Exactly. Sit down, freshie."

"Don't call me that."

"All right, freshie."

Connor threw a rolled-up T-shirt at him.

Jamo caught it.

That was more or less the beginning of their friendship.

Jamo had been in six months.

To Connor, six months sounded like expertise.

Jamo knew who worked where.

Who was all right.

Who talked too much.

Which officers would answer an application and which would apparently rather die.

When gym lists went up.

Which days canteen became the most important event in the building.

Which televisions lost signal for no reason.

How long laundry could disappear for before you accepted your clothes had started a new life.

He also knew everyone.

Or claimed to.

"See him?" Jamo said later, standing near the cell door.

Connor looked out.

"Which one?"

"Skinny ginger bloke."

Connor found him.

Bruce was talking to three different people while eating something from a packet.

"Bruce."

"What about him?"

"Mental."

"Helpful."

"No, like properly. But funny mental. Don't judge him off the size of him either. People got stories."

"What stories?"

Jamo looked delighted to have been asked.

"You'll hear."

Connor frowned.

"Why does everybody say that in here?"

"Because telling you everything at once ruins the week."

Jamo nodded elsewhere.

"Malik. Knows everyone's business before they do."

"Why?"

"No one knows. Think he sleeps in the walls."

"Who's the big one?"

"Leon. Gym. Lives there mentally even when he's not there."

"And him?"

"Macca. Family man. Don't bother him when he's waiting for a call unless you want a twenty-minute lecture about respect."

Connor kept looking.

"Darren?"

Jamo found him farther down.

"Yeah. Darren."

Something about Jamo's tone changed slightly.

"What?"

"Nothing. He's all right. Just... Darren."

Connor looked at him.

"That explained loads."

"You'll see."

There it was again.

Connor shook his head.

"Who else?"

Jamo looked down the wing.

"Mason you already know. Induction orderly. Been in and out enough he probably has a loyalty card."

Connor laughed.

"Craig's on here too, yeah?"

Jamo turned his head slowly.

"Of course that's who you ask about."

"I know him."

Jamo stared at him.

"You know him?"

"I've spoken to him."

"That's not the same sentence."

Connor smiled.

"He came in when I did."

Jamo looked genuinely impressed for the first time.

That feeling went straight into Connor's chest.

It was tiny.

But it was there.

The first little reward for being near Craig.
Connor did not recognise it as dangerous.
Not yet.

JINX - A WING

Jinx heard Craig had moved to C before he
heard what had happened by the showers.

That told him something about priorities.

Rico heard too.

"C," Rico said.

"I know."

"You know everything today."

"Only because you keep announcing it."

Rico sat nearby.

"Makes things easier."

Jinx looked at him.

"For who?"

Rico did not answer.

Jinx had started noticing that silence from Rico was more worrying than talking.

The money had not disappeared.

If anything, moving Craig onto a main wing had made the story feel closer.

Jinx looked toward the door.

Different wing.

Same prison.

That was the problem.

People liked talking as if A and C were different countries.

Trouble rarely respected geography for long.

JAMO

That night Jamo talked through the dark as if silence personally offended him.

Connor lay on the top bunk listening.

"So what you in for?" Jamo asked.

Connor stared at the ceiling.

"Burglary."

"Normal burglary?"

"Aggravated."

Jamo went quiet for perhaps two seconds.

"Oh."

Connor smiled into the dark.

"What?"

"Nothing."

"Say it."

"Was gonna say you don't look like an aggravated burglar."

"What's one look like?"

"More aggravated."

Connor laughed.

It came out louder than he expected.

Jamo laughed too.

For the first time since Friday night, Connor had a conversation after lights-out that did not involve police, lawyers or his own imagination.

That mattered more than he knew.

C Wing was louder than G.

Doors. Voices. Toilets flushing inside cells.
Someone shouting something from farther
along. A television through a wall.

Connor listened.

"You get used to it," Jamo said.

Connor turned his head.

"You asleep?"

"No."

"Then how'd you know what I was thinking?"

"Freshie thoughts are predictable."

Connor smiled.

"Shut up."

"Night, freshie."

"Fuck off."

Jamo laughed again.

Connor closed his eyes.

For the first time, Lewes contained somebody
he could imagine becoming a mate.

FRIDAY 27 SEPTEMBER 2019 - LINES

LEON - A WING / GYM

Leon liked prison best when it behaved like a timetable.

Wake up.

Work.

Gym.

Eat.

Read.

Sleep.

Repeat.

People called that boring.

Leon called it control.

Control was precious because almost everything else belonged to somebody else.

Doors opened when staff decided.

Visits happened when the system allowed them.

Court dates moved.

Applications disappeared.

Family problems happened miles away and waited for nobody.

But a set of repetitions was still a set of repetitions.

Leon could own that.

He was checking a list when Deano appeared.

"You heard about Craig?"

Leon did not look up.

"I've heard about Craig every day since Monday."

"Money's real."

"Good for money."

Deano leaned against the wall.

"People are asking where everyone stands."

Leon finally looked at him.

"I stand here."

"You know what I mean."

"Then you know my answer."

Deano sighed.

Leon went back to the list.

"I'm not involved."

"Sometimes not being involved gets taken as a side."

"That's their problem."

Deano smiled without much humour.

"Eventually it becomes yours."

He left.

Leon watched him go.

Then looked back at the list.

One thing at a time.

That was how he survived.

JINX - A WING

Rico had become irritatingly quiet.

Jinx preferred him loud.

Loud Rico was obvious.

Quiet Rico meant thoughts.

"You spoken to anyone?" Jinx asked.

"About what?"

"Don't do that."

"Do what?"

"That thing where you act thick because you think it makes me tired."

Rico smiled.

Better.

"No."

Jinx did not believe him completely.

He did not completely disbelieve him either.

Prison lived in that gap.

"Listen," Jinx said. "People outside can promise whatever they want. They ain't the ones doing the consequences."

Rico rubbed his hands together.

"You sound old."

"And you sound unemployed."

"We are in prison."

"Exactly. Think about how badly you've done to get here before taking career advice."

Rico laughed.

Jinx smiled too.

Then his face changed.

"I'm serious. Leave Craig alone."

Rico looked away.

"I ain't said nothing about Craig."

"Good. Keep saying nothing."

Jinx did not know yet how much he would come to regret not pushing harder.

CONNOR - C WING

Jamo had rules for the cell.

Connor discovered this after breaking three of them.

"Don't leave that there."

"It's a towel."

"Exactly. Wet towel. My side."

"Your side?"

Jamo pointed at an invisible border running through the centre of the cell.

"My side. Your side. Civilisation."

Connor looked around the tiny room.

"You know we share a toilet, yeah?"

"Don't undermine the system."

Connor laughed and moved the towel.

Jamo nodded approvingly.

"See? Prison rehabilitating you already."

Connor threw a sock at him.

Their morning was interrupted by somebody calling Connor's name from outside.

Not Blake.

Connor.

He looked through the door.

Craig was farther along.

Jamo immediately noticed.

"Your boyfriend's calling you."

"Shut up."

"Tell him you've got cell responsibilities."

Connor walked out smiling.

Craig waited until he reached him.

"Settling in?"

"Jamo's got a constitution."

"Good cellmate?"

Connor glanced back.

Jamo was openly watching them.

"Yeah. Talks too much."

"Could say the same about you."

"You keep saying that."

"You keep proving it."

They walked a short distance.

Connor had noticed people looking at them differently since moving to C.

He did not understand whether they were looking at Craig or looking at him because he was beside Craig.

He liked the second possibility more than he should have.

"You know everyone's talking about you?"

Connor asked.

Craig sighed.

"Apparently I'm very popular."

"There's money."

Craig stopped.

Not dramatically.

Just enough.

Connor noticed.

"Who told you?"

"Everyone."

"Then nobody told you anything."

"What does that mean?"

"Means gossip with no source is just weather."

Connor frowned.

"You ain't worried?"

Craig looked at him.

"Would it make you feel better if I was?"

Connor did not know how to answer.

Craig carried on walking.

Connor followed.

He had started doing that without noticing.

OFFICER BENNETT

Bennett had spent the morning convincing himself he was not being watched.

That was difficult because he kept checking whether he was being watched.

Every glance became meaningful.

Every prisoner speaking quietly became about him.

Every colleague asking if he was all right sounded suspicious.

He knew that was paranoia.

Knowing did not stop it.

At lunch Senior Officer Patel asked him to stay behind for a second.

Bennett's stomach tightened.

"Yeah?"

Patel held up a piece of paper.

"You missed this yesterday."

Bennett stared at it.

A routine form.

Nothing.

"Right. Sorry."

Patel looked at him.

"You sure you're all right?"

"Yeah. Just not sleeping great."

"Kid?"

"Kid."

It was becoming useful having a child.

Nobody questioned tiredness when you had a child.

Patel nodded.

"Get some sleep. You're no use to anyone half-dead."

Bennett forced a smile.

"I'll tell the baby."

He left before his face could betray the relief.

The problem was that relief now lasted minutes.

Then the fear returned.

MACCA - C WING

Macca had been waiting for the phone for forty minutes when somebody tried to tell him about Craig.

"Not now."

"You ain't even heard what I was gonna say."

"If it's about Craig, I don't care."

"It is."

"Then look at that. Saved us both time."

The man laughed and moved on.

Macca checked the clock.

His partner had said she would be home by seven.

His daughter had been having trouble sleeping.

Nothing serious.

That was the problem with prison.

Nothing serious outside could become enormous when you could not be there.

A bad night.

A school problem.

A bill.

A child asking why Dad was not home.

Macca could do almost nothing except ring and offer advice nobody needed from a man locked miles away.

When he finally got through, his partner answered sounding exhausted.

"You all right?" he asked.

"Do I sound all right?"

"No."

"Then why ask?"

Macca closed his eyes.

Behind him somebody shouted about canteen.

Someone else laughed.

Craig's name floated through another conversation.

Macca turned his back on all of it.

"Put her on."

"She's just gone to sleep."

He felt the disappointment physically.

"Oh."

"I'll tell her you rang."

"Yeah."

A pause.

"She asked this morning if you're coming home for her birthday."

Macca looked at the wall.

"What'd you say?"

"What do you think I said?"

Macca rubbed his face.

The biggest story in Lewes that evening was apparently Craig.

Macca could not have cared less.

His daughter had asked if he was coming home.

That was his prison.

MALIK - C WING

Malik now had six versions of the same story.

The amount varied.

The reason varied.

Big Sharky's involvement was either obvious, impossible or confirmed by somebody's cousin depending on who was speaking.

One thing remained constant.

People were no longer laughing about it.

Malik watched Craig moving through the wing.

Connor was not far away.

Interesting.

The young lad had been there less than a week and was already appearing in the

background of conversations he did not understand.

Malik found Bruce leaning near a wall eating crisps.

"You heard anything?"

Bruce looked at him.

"About what?"

"Craig."

Bruce chewed slowly.

"Craig's tall enough to hear things himself. Ask him."

"You're useless."

"Incorrect. I'm recreational."

Malik laughed despite himself.

Bruce pointed a crisp at him.

"See, that's value."

Then he walked off.

Malik watched him go.

Nobody knew where Bruce got half his information.

Nobody knew why Bruce sometimes refused to give the half he had.

That made Malik trust him more than most people who claimed to know everything.

CONNOR

That night Jamo was talking about Enhanced status.

Connor had barely understood Standard yet.

"Extra gym," Jamo said. "More canteen. More visits. That's what you want."

"How long?"

"Depends. Keep your nose clean. Do education. Work. Don't be a dickhead to staff."

Connor looked down from the top bunk.

"So you're fucked."

Jamo laughed.

"I'm serious. I'm trying to get visits orderly."

"Why?"

Jamo stared at him.

"Because you get off the wing. You're busy.
Trusted job. Day goes quicker."

Connor had not thought about prison jobs as something anybody wanted.

"I'm gonna get gym."

"You're gonna get a mop."

"Fuck off."

"You got here Monday and you're already best mates with the most watched man in the prison. They're not giving you the keys to Buckingham Palace."

Connor laughed.

But Jamo was serious underneath it.

Six months inside and he had a plan.

Education.

No trouble.

Visits orderly.

Enhanced.

Connor had been inside five days and did not yet know what his plan was beyond tomorrow.

From the bunk below, Jamo said:

"Just don't make our cell famous, yeah?"

Connor smiled into the dark.

"Why would I do that?"

Neither of them knew yet.

SATURDAY 28 SEPTEMBER 2019

- PRESSURE

DEANO - A WING

Deano's main ambition was to keep other people's dramas from becoming his.

Prison made that surprisingly difficult.

He had friends.

Friends had friends.

Friends of friends had brothers outside.

Brothers outside had opinions.

By the time an opinion travelled through enough people, somebody on a wing was expected to prove loyalty to a problem they had not known existed on Monday.

Deano sat opposite one of his lads and listened to a version of the Craig story that contained a number large enough to become stupid.

"That's bollocks," Deano said.

"It's not."

"It is because every time someone tells me, it goes up. By next Tuesday they'll be offering a house in Spain."

"People are serious."

"That's what worries me."

The man looked at him.

"So what are we doing?"

"Nothing."

"People might think-"

"Let them think. Thinking's free."

"You know what I mean."

Deano did.

He hated that he did.

Neutrality was easy when nobody cared what you thought.

The moment everybody cared, neutrality started looking like disloyalty to someone.

"This ain't our feud," Deano said.

"Might not matter."

Deano leaned back.

"Then we'll make it matter."

He sounded more confident than he felt.

PHONE CALL

The voice on the line said the attempt had not happened yet.

There was a pause.

Then Big Sharky's voice:

"I know."

"People are nervous."

"Then they're nervous."

"You want-"

"I want what I said."

The other man went quiet.

Big Sharky did not raise his voice.

"Stop ringing me to tell me people are thinking."

The call ended.

By the time the message reached Lewes, it had acquired three extra sentences Big Sharky had never said.

That was how prison worked.

Silence was never allowed to remain empty.

CONNOR - C WING

Connor was cleaning nothing yet.

He had no job.

That meant Saturday had too many hours in it.

Jamo had been explaining prison employment again as if he worked for recruitment.

"Laundry's all right."

"No."

"Servery?"

"No."

"Wing cleaner."

"Definitely no."

"That's where you're going."

"Why are you obsessed with me having a mop?"

"Because I can see the future."

Connor looked at him.

"You can't even see your own socks."

Jamo looked around.

"Where are my socks?"

Connor laughed.

The cell door was open.

Saturday noise moved past them.

Someone arguing about the gym list.

Someone else asking where an application had gone.

A man farther down shouting that his canteen was wrong.

Jamo pointed outside.

"That's prison, by the way."

"What?"

"Everyone thinks it's stabbings and riots. It's actually thirty men trying to find out where their noodles went."

Connor smiled.

Then Bruce appeared in the doorway.

Not walked up.

Appeared.

Connor was starting to understand that Bruce treated entrances as optional.

"Anyone got tea bags?"

Jamo stared at him.

"You had tea bags this morning."

"That was Morning Bruce. Different department."

Connor laughed.

Bruce looked at him.

"See? He understands administration."

"What happened to your tea bags?" Jamo asked.

Bruce looked offended.

"I used them. That's what tea bags are for. I'm not breeding them."

Jamo threw him two.

Bruce caught them and pointed at Connor.

"Keep your eyes open tomorrow."

Connor's smile faded slightly.

"Why?"

Bruce shrugged.

"Sunday. Weird day. God rests, screws get bored, prisoners discover ambitions."

Jamo stared at him.

"What does that mean?"

"No idea. Sounded excellent though."

Bruce walked away.

Connor watched him go.

"Is he actually mental?"

Jamo considered it.

"Depends what day."

Connor laughed again.

But Bruce's first sentence stayed.

Keep your eyes open tomorrow.

OFFICER MERCER

Mercer hated atmosphere because atmosphere did not fit neatly on paperwork.

There was no box for:

Wing feels wrong.

No drop-down menu for:

Too many men suddenly pretending not to care about the same thing.

She wanted facts.

What she had was quiet conversations ending when staff approached.

Malik somehow knowing less than usual.

Jinx's name appearing near intelligence without anything concrete attached to him.

And Connor Blake spending increasing amounts of time around Craig.

She found Connor later.

"You got a hobby?"

Connor looked confused.

"What?"

"Something that isn't Craig."

He laughed.

"I'm not following him around."

Mercer looked over Connor's shoulder.

Craig was ten feet away.

Connor followed her eyes.

"That's coincidence."

"You've had a very coincidental week."

"He's all right."

"That's not the point."

"What's the point then?"

Mercer lowered her voice slightly.

"You don't know what other people bring with them."

Connor's face changed.

Only a little.

"People keep saying there's stuff going on."

"Then stop trying to be the person who finds out first."

"I'm not."

"Blake."

He sighed.

"All right."

Mercer knew from experience that young men saying all right often meant they had heard every word and accepted none of it.

"Keep your head on your own sentence," she said.

Connor nodded.

For perhaps six minutes, he intended to.

MASON - M WING / INDUCTION

Mason found Connor later in the day looking across the wing as if the answers might be written above people's heads.

"You look busy," Mason said.

"I'm sitting down."

"Exactly. Exhausting."

Connor smiled.

Mason sat nearby.

For a while they said nothing.

Connor broke first.

Of course he did.

"Everyone keeps warning me."

"Maybe you're very warnable."

"About Craig."

Mason nodded.

"There it is."

"You know what's going on?"

"Some."

"Tell me."

"No."

Connor frowned.

"Why?"

Mason looked at him.

"Because knowing something and needing to repeat it are two different things."

"That's annoying."

"Useful things often are."

Connor leaned back.

"So what am I meant to do? Just walk around knowing nothing?"

Mason shook his head.

"Other way round."

Connor waited.

Mason pointed lightly toward Connor's eyes.

"Hear all."

Then his ears, because Mason enjoyed being difficult.

"See all."

Connor laughed.

"You got those backwards."

"You listening or marking me?"

"Go on."

Mason's expression settled.

"Say nothing."

Connor looked at him.

Mason continued.

"Watch. Learn. You don't need to prove you heard something. You don't need to stick your nose in every problem because you know a name. Half the trouble in jail starts because somebody can't stand knowing something quietly."

Connor considered it.

"Hear all. See all. Say nothing."

"There you go."

"Sounds deep."

"It isn't. It's three short instructions. That's why I thought you might manage it."

Connor laughed.

Mason stood.

"Seriously, lad. You don't need to be in every story."

He walked away.

Connor watched him go.

The words stayed.

Hear all.

See all.

Say nothing.

Connor liked the sound of them.

Understanding them would take longer.

DARREN - C WING

Darren had spent most of the day trying not to feel ill.

Craig could have been crowned king of England on the landing and Darren might not have noticed.

His world was smaller.

Immediate.

Body first.

Everything else later.

Macca passed him and slowed.

"You look rough."

Darren gave him a tired smile.

"Cheers. Been working on it."

"You all right?"

"Perfect."

"You look perfect if perfect's been left in a bin overnight."

Darren laughed despite himself.

"Fuck off."

Macca carried on.

Darren leaned against the wall.

He knew what people said.

Darren looks bad these days.

Darren's bang on the spine.

Darren's losing it.

Sometimes they were wrong.

Sometimes they were not wrong enough.

Officer Grant saw him from farther down.

Their eyes met.

Grant gave the smallest nod toward the office area.

Darren's stomach tightened for a different reason.

He looked away.

There were many ways to owe people in prison.

Darren was collecting too many of them.

BRUCE

Bruce found Malik near the end of association.

"You keep asking everyone what's happening tomorrow."

Malik looked at him.

"Do I?"

"Yes. It's making you look needy."

"And you know?"

Bruce scratched his chin.

"I know tomorrow is Sunday."

"Brilliant."

"Also know people are being idiots."

"Which people?"

Bruce looked around the wing.

"Statistically? Most."

Malik laughed.

Bruce turned to leave.

"Bruce."

He looked back.

"What?"

"You actually worried?"

For once Bruce did not answer immediately.

Then:

"I don't like rooms where everyone thinks they're the only person with a secret."

Malik's smile faded.

Bruce walked away before Malik could ask anything else.

SUNDAY 29 SEPTEMBER 2019 - THE CHOICE

JINX - A WING

Jinx knew something was wrong because Rico had stopped talking.

Rico talked when he was nervous.

Talked when he was excited.

Talked when he had nothing to say and treated the absence of material as a personal challenge.

This morning he was quiet.

Jinx found him near breakfast.

"You all right?"

"Yeah."

"You look terrible."

"Cheers."

"What you doing today?"

Rico looked at him.

There.

Tiny pause.

Too tiny for anybody who did not know him.

"Nothing."

Jinx's stomach tightened.

"Rico."

"What?"

"Don't be stupid."

Rico laughed.

"Everyone says that to me like I'm planning something."

Jinx did not laugh.

"Are you?"

Rico's face closed.

"No."

Jinx believed half of it.

That was not enough.

"Whatever people outside are telling you, they don't serve the time."

"I know."

"Do you?"

Rico looked away.

Jinx lowered his voice.

"Money sounds different when you're broke. I get it. But it ain't magic. It doesn't make consequences disappear."

Rico shrugged.

"I said I'm doing nothing."

He walked off.

Jinx watched him go.

For the first time, Jinx considered telling staff something.

The thought felt like betrayal even though he had nothing concrete to tell them.

That annoyed him.

Prison loyalty had a habit of demanding certainty from people who had none.

He looked across the wing for Rico again.

Gone.

OFFICER MERCER

Mercer had a bad feeling.

She hated bad feelings.

Bad feelings were professionally useless.

You could not write the wing felt weird on a formal record and expect applause.

She wanted information.

Names.

Statements.

Something concrete.

Instead she had men becoming quieter when officers approached, Malik suddenly pretending he had forgotten every rumour he had ever heard, and Bennett looking as though he had not slept for a month.

"Anything?" she asked Patel.

"Noise."

"Same."

"Craig?"

"Around him. Not from him."

Patel nodded.

That distinction mattered.

Craig had been mostly compliant since arriving. The problem was everything collecting around him.

Mercer looked across the area where several prisoners were waiting for movement.

Connor sat beside Craig.

Of course he did.

She caught Connor's eye.

He gave her a small, guilty smile as if she had caught him sitting in the wrong seat at school.

Mercer shook her head.

Connor smiled wider.

Craig noticed the exchange.

He said something to Connor.

Connor laughed.

Mercer had the inconvenient thought that Craig seemed good with him.

Not useful.

She filed it away anyway.

CONNOR - C WING

"Mercer hates me," Connor said.

Craig looked over.

"Officer Mercer?"

"Yeah."

"She doesn't hate you."

"Keeps staring at me."

"Maybe she likes your top."

Connor looked at him.

"You already used that one."

"Still works."

They were waiting again.

Everything in prison appeared to be preparation for waiting, followed by waiting for the next preparation.

Connor had stopped asking when things would start.

That felt like institutional progress.

"Mason reckons there's talk about you," he said.

Craig's face did not change.

"Mason talks a lot for someone who warns people about talk."

"He said people are interested."

"People have hobbies."

"Bruce said keep my eyes open."

Craig sighed.

"Bruce's main hobby is making people think he knows more than he does."

"Does he?"

"Unfortunately, sometimes."

Connor leaned back.

"So there is something."

Craig looked at him.

"Connor."

"What?"

"You ever had a dog chase a car?"

"What?"

"Dog runs after it barking like mad. Car stops. Dog has no idea what to do next."

Connor frowned.

"Are you the car?"

"I'm saying don't chase every bit of noise because you want to know where it ends."

"That is the most old-man thing anyone's said to me all week."

"Mason will be devastated."

Connor laughed.

A door opened somewhere.

Men shifted.

An officer called for people to move.

Connor stood.

So did Craig.

Nothing about the next ten seconds announced itself.

That was what Connor remembered afterwards.

No warning.

No silence falling across the room.

One man simply moved too quickly.

Connor saw the movement before he understood it.

The man drove through the group towards Craig.

Craig turned.

Connor did not think.

Thinking would have taken too long.

He caught Craig by the sleeve and dragged him half a step sideways while stepping into the space Craig had just occupied.

The first collision hit Connor instead.

It knocked the breath out of him and sent him sideways into the edge of a bench.

For a second his arm went numb.

He could have stayed there.

He didn't.

Connor pushed himself upright just as a second man came in from Craig's other side.

There was no time to work out who he was or what exactly Connor had stepped into.

Craig was turning towards the first man.

The second was already coming.

Connor stepped between them.

The second man crashed into him.

Someone grabbed at Connor's top. Connor shoved back. Feet scraped across the floor. A chair went over behind them.

Craig was moving now as well, no longer caught by surprise, forcing space between himself and the first man.

Connor took another hard knock in the side and went into the wall.

Pain flashed through him.

For half a second he thought: stay down.

Then he saw the first man trying to come forward again.

Connor got back up.

He shoved himself back beside Craig.

Not in front of him now.

Beside him.

That was the bit people remembered.

The alarm was screaming by then.

Officers were shouting.

Men who had been standing nearby suddenly wanted to be nowhere near any of it.

"BACK! BACK NOW!"

Connor barely heard the order.

An officer forced between the men. Another grabbed Connor and hauled him away from Craig.

Connor twisted round on instinct.

"I'm not fucking-"

"STOP!"

More staff arrived at a run.

The whole thing collapsed into bodies being separated, orders being shouted and doors opening and slamming.

Connor was restrained before he had properly understood that, to officers arriving late, he

looked exactly like another prisoner in the fight.

"I weren't with them!"

"You'll explain it later."

"They went for him!"

"Blake, stop moving."

Connor stopped.

Craig was several feet away now with staff between them.

The two men who had come at him were being held separately.

Nobody was listening to explanations yet.

Then came the order for everyone else to get behind their doors.

The landing emptied in fragments.

Connor caught one last look at Craig.

Craig looked back.

Not grateful.

Not angry.

Surprised.

Then Connor was taken away.

MASON - M WING

The story reached Mason before the facts did.

Of course it did.

By the time men were behind their doors, Connor had apparently fought three people, Craig had fought six, somebody had a weapon, nobody had a weapon, and one version had Connor saving Craig's life single-handedly.

Mason believed almost none of it.

What he did believe was the part repeated in every version.

Connor had moved towards the trouble.

"Idiot," Mason said quietly.

There was affection in it, which annoyed him.

He thought about the advice he had given the lad.

Hear all.

See all.

Say nothing.

Apparently he should have added:

*And when trouble starts beside you, don't
volunteer for a practical demonstration.*

OFFICER MERCER - AFTER THE ALARM

The prisoner version of an incident began before staff had finished dealing with the actual one.

Mercer dealt with what she could establish.

Who moved first.

Who was where.

What staff had seen.

What the cameras might show.

Connor was a problem because he had unquestionably joined the physical confrontation.

That did not mean he had joined the attack.

Those were two different things.

In the first seconds after the alarm, nobody had the luxury of making that distinction.

Connor, Craig and the two men who had come at him were all separated.

The rest of the wing was put behind doors while staff brought the situation under control.

Mercer watched part of the CCTV later with Patel.

There it was.

The first man moved at Craig.

Connor reacted afterwards.

Not planned.

Not waiting.

Not moving with the attackers.

He pulled Craig aside, took the collision himself, got knocked away and then got back up when the second man came in.

Patel paused the footage.

"Stupid," he said.

Mercer looked at the frozen image of Connor halfway back to his feet.

"Yes."

"Brave."

Mercer hated that she agreed with that too.

"Also stupid."

Patel restarted the footage.

The two original attackers would remain off the normal wing while the incident was dealt with.

Connor's position was different.

The footage supported what he had been shouting from the beginning: he had not arrived as part of the attack.

But he had still thrown himself into it.

He would spend the night separated from the wing while everything was untangled.

Mercer suspected the night alone would do more to him than any lecture she could give.

JINX - A WING

Rico was gone from normal association by evening.

Jinx did not need anybody to explain why.

The attempt had failed.

Connor had been taken away too.

That detail travelled almost as fast as the fight.

"They got the new kid as well," somebody said.

Jinx looked at him.

"Course they did. He jumped in."

"You reckon he's involved?"

"No."

"How do you know?"

Jinx thought about Rico's face that morning.

Thought about Connor walking around the prison barely understanding his own situation, let alone everybody else's.

"Because that boy doesn't know enough to be involved in anything yet."

The man laughed.

Jinx did not.

That was no longer completely true.

Connor knew Craig now.

And after today, everybody knew Connor.

CONNOR - SEGREGATION

The worst part was how quickly the noise disappeared.

One minute alarms, shouting, bodies, officers, Craig, pain in his side.

Then a door closed.

And Connor was alone.

He sat on the bed and stared at the wall.

His body still thought the fight was happening.

His hands would not quite settle.

His breathing took too long to slow down.

He replayed it.

The first man moving.

Craig turning.

Connor stepping in.

The bench.

Getting back up.

The second man.

The officers grabbing him.

Again.

Again.

Again.

He tried to work out the exact second when he could have chosen differently.

There were several.

That was the problem.

He could have moved away at the start.

He could have stayed down after the first collision.

He could have let Craig deal with his own problem.

Instead he had gone back.

Why?

Connor did not have an answer that sounded clever.

He barely knew Craig.

He did not know why people wanted to hurt him.

He did not know who the two men were.

He did not know whether tomorrow he would go back to C Wing or whether he had just made himself part of something much larger than his own case.

Mason's voice came back to him.

Hear all. See all. Say nothing.

Connor almost laughed.

"Forgot the important bit, didn't you?" he muttered to the empty cell.

What do you do when your body moves before your brain?

Nobody had given him advice for that.

He lay back and looked at the ceiling.

For the first time since arriving at Lewes,
Connor was not thinking about fifteen years.

He was thinking about ten seconds.

Ten seconds that might have changed every
day that came after them.

MONDAY 30 SEPTEMBER 2019 - RUSH

CONNOR - SEGREGATION

Connor slept badly.

That was generous.

Mostly he lay down with his eyes shut while his brain replayed ten seconds from Sunday at different speeds.

By morning he had changed the ending twenty times.

In some versions he stayed down after the first collision.

In some he moved away before anything started.

In one particularly stupid version he somehow noticed everything early enough to warn Craig, staff and himself and everybody thanked him for being sensible.

Reality refused to cooperate.

He had got up.

Then got up again.

Now he was sitting alone waiting to find out what that had bought him.

The door opened.

An officer looked in.

"Blake. Get your things together."

Connor stood.

"Where am I going?"

"Back to C."

Relief hit him first.

Then nerves.

Prison officers had a talent for making good news sound like a parking ticket.

"That's it?"

The officer looked at him.

"You want somewhere else?"

"No."

"Then get your things."

Connor did.

MALIK - C WING

By breakfast Malik had heard Connor was coming back.

This was impressive because Connor himself probably did not know yet.

The story of Sunday had settled into a shape.
Not a truthful shape.

A prison shape.

Craig had been rushed.

Two men had moved on him.

Connor had stepped in.

Connor had been knocked away.

Connor had got back up.

That last part survived every version.

Malik found that interesting.

Details changed when people exaggerated.

The bits that did not change were usually the bits worth remembering.

Bruce appeared beside him.

"He's coming back."

Malik looked over.

"Who told you?"

"A bird landed on the exercise yard and whispered it."

"Seriously."

"Why ask if you're gonna reject my sources?"

Malik laughed.

Bruce looked toward the landing.

"Needs a name."

"He's already got one. Connor."

Bruce shook his head.

"That's government thinking."

Malik stared at him.

"What does that even mean?"

"You'll see."

Bruce wandered off.

Malik watched him go.

That phrase again.

Everyone in prison eventually became Mason by accident.

OFFICER MERCER

Mercer saw Connor before he saw her.

He looked tired.

Not injured badly.

Not triumphant either.

Good.

She had worried the wing might turn the incident into a medal before Connor had time to understand it.

That was still possible.

He reached C and the noise found him before the people did.

A voice called from farther down.

"Here he is."

Mercer saw Bruce straighten.

Of course.

She almost felt sorry for Connor.

Almost.

CONNOR - C WING

Connor heard normal wing noise before he saw the landing properly.

That unsettled him.

Sunday had ended with alarms and shouting and doors slamming.

Monday sounded as if nothing had happened.

Someone arguing about breakfast.

A television too loud.

An officer calling a name.

Somebody laughing.

The wing had continued without him.

Connor stepped onto C.

Heads turned.

Not everybody.

Enough.

Bruce spotted him first.

"Here he is."

Connor adjusted the small bundle he was carrying.

Bruce pointed at him like he had discovered something scientifically significant.

"Rush."

Connor stopped.

"What?"

Jamo was in the cell doorway.

He started laughing.

Connor looked between them.

"What the fuck is Rush?"

Bruce walked closer.

"You."

"No it's not."

"Saw trouble. Rushed straight into it. Got knocked away. Rushed back in."

Bruce spread his hands.

"Rush."

Jamo was properly laughing now.

"That's actually decent."

Connor stared at him.

"Don't encourage him."

Bruce nodded toward Jamo.

"Independent panel agrees."

"There is no panel."

"Democracy doesn't need stationery."

Connor shook his head and started walking toward the cell.

Someone farther down called:

"Oi, Rush!"

Connor turned automatically.

Bruce pointed at him in triumph.

"See? Democracy."

The landing laughed.

Connor did too, eventually.

He told himself it was stupid.

It was stupid.

That did not stop something inside him enjoying the fact everybody knew why the name existed.

By the time he reached his cell, the name had travelled farther down the landing than he had.

JAMO

Jamo waited until Connor put his things down.

Then:

"You all right?"

Connor nodded.

"Yeah."

Jamo looked at him.

"Actually?"

Connor sat on the bunk.

"Didn't sleep."

"Block?"

"Yeah."

Jamo whistled quietly.

"First week and you've done reception, G, C, fight and the block. Efficient."

Connor laughed.

"Didn't fight."

Jamo raised an eyebrow.

"You were physically involved in a violent disagreement."

"Fuck off."

"I'm practising for court."

Connor shook his head.

Jamo sat opposite.

The humour left him a little.

"Why'd you do it?"

Connor looked down.

"Everyone keeps asking that."

"Probably because nobody understands it."

"I don't understand it."

Jamo accepted that.

For a moment neither spoke.

Then Jamo smiled.

"Rush though."

Connor threw a sock at him.

"I'm moving out."

"You just got back."

"Already sick of you."

Jamo caught the sock and threw it back.

For that morning at least, they were still just cellmates taking the piss.

BRUCE

Bruce considered the naming matter complete.

Malik did not.

"You know you've probably just stuck that on him for years."

Bruce shrugged.

"Could've been worse."

"What were the other options?"

Bruce thought.

"Bench."

Malik stared at him.

"Bench?"

"He hit one."

"That's terrible."

"Exactly. Rush won fairly."

Malik shook his head.

Bruce opened a packet of biscuits.

"Names are like mould. If they stick, it's because conditions were right."

Malik looked at him.

"You ever hear yourself?"

"Constantly. Big fan."

He walked off eating a biscuit.

CONNOR

Craig found Connor later.

Not the other way around.

That mattered to Connor more than he wanted it to.

"Connor."

Connor turned.

Craig was leaning nearby, looking exactly as calm as he had before Sunday.

"You all right?"

"Yeah."

Craig looked him over.

"You sure?"

"Bit sore."

"You'll live."

"Cheers, doctor."

Craig smiled faintly.

Then silence.

Connor expected thanks.

He hated himself slightly for expecting it.

Craig did not give him the speech he had imagined.

Instead he asked:

"Why'd you get back up?"

Connor looked at him.

There it was again.

The question.

"Dunno."

Craig waited.

Connor hated people who waited better than him.

"You were still there," he said eventually.

Craig's expression changed almost imperceptibly.

"Most people move the other way."

Connor shrugged.

"I'm not most people then."

Craig looked at him for another second.

"No. Probably not."

Connor looked down the wing.

"They're calling me Rush now."

"I heard."

"You gonna call me that?"

"No."

Connor frowned.

"Why not?"

Craig looked at him.

"Because I know your name."

Then he walked away.

Connor stood still.

He pretended that sentence did not mean anything.

It did.

MASON - M WING

Mason heard the nickname before lunch.

Of course he did.

Prison could take six weeks to answer an application and six minutes to rename a man.

"Rush," Mason said to himself.

He shook his head.

The lad had been inside a week.

Already prison had started writing on him.

Mason wondered whether Connor understood that names were rarely just names in here.

Probably not.

Then again, Mason had been giving young men advice for years and they normally understood it shortly after doing the opposite.

He went back to work.

Connor would learn.

The only question was what it would cost him.

TUESDAY 1 OCTOBER 2019 - THE NAME STICKS

CONNOR - C WING

By Tuesday morning, Connor had learned something depressing about prison.

A nickname could spread faster than breakfast.

He came out of his cell and heard it before he reached the stairs.

"Rush."

Connor ignored it.

"Oi, Rush."

Still ignored it.

"Connor Blake, previously known as Rush."

Connor turned.

Bruce was leaning against the rail with a mug in one hand.

"You're ruining it," Connor said.

"Ruining what?"

"If you're gonna nickname someone, you're not meant to shout their government name after it."

Bruce considered this.

"That's fair."

Connor started walking again.

"Rush."

He stopped.

Bruce smiled into his mug.

Connor laughed despite himself.

The name had become real overnight.

Not official real.

Nothing useful in prison was official real.

Officially he was still Connor Blake, prison number attached, case attached, age attached, allegation attached.

On C Wing he was becoming Rush.

That version of him had a story.

The story was better than the truth.

The truth was that Connor had panicked, moved before thinking and spent the next night wondering whether he had just made the worst decision of his life.

The story was that he had seen two men move on Craig and gone straight in without fear.

Connor knew which version he preferred people repeating.

That worried him less than it should have.

Breakfast was ordinary enough to insult him.

That was another thing prison seemed good at.

The day after something enormous happened to you, somebody still wanted to know whether you were having cereal.

Connor stood near the servery while two men argued because one believed he'd been given the wrong thing.

"I said no porridge."

"Then don't eat it."

"That's not the point."

"Looks exactly like the point from here."

Connor watched them.

Jamo appeared beside him.

"Deep prison politics," he said.

"Porridge?"

"Starts with porridge. Ends with NATO."

Connor laughed.

Jamo nodded towards a table.

"Come on."

They sat.

Two lads Connor had barely spoken to before Sunday acknowledged him on the way past.

One gave him a nod.

The other said, "All right, Rush?"

Connor nodded back.

Jamo saw it.

Connor knew he saw it because Jamo's face changed by about half a millimetre.

"What?" Connor said.

"Nothing."

"You did a face."

"Didn't."

"You did."

"Maybe I've got wind."

Connor smiled.

Jamo tore open a packet.

"You've been here eight days and you've got more people saying hello to you than me."

The line was delivered like a joke.

Mostly it was.

Connor leaned back.

"Natural charisma."

"Natural dickhead."

"Same thing in here, apparently."

Jamo laughed.

The moment passed.

But not completely.

JAMO

Jamo liked Connor.

That was the annoying bit.

If Connor had been a complete prick, things would have been easier.

Instead he was funny, generous with his canteen when he had any, listened when Jamo explained things and, most importantly, had arrived knowing absolutely nothing.

For the first few days Jamo had enjoyed that.

He knew where things were.

He knew the routines.

He knew which officer would tell you to put an application in and which officer would then lose the application with almost artistic consistency.

He knew when gym lists went up.

He knew which laundry bag was likely to come back missing a sock.

He knew enough to feel useful.

Then Connor stepped into one fight and the whole wing learned his name.

Jamo told himself he did not care.

Mostly he didn't.

He had his own plan.

Education for now.

Keep his head down.

No stupid nickings.

No unnecessary arguments with staff.

Keep Standard clean, push toward Enhanced, and get his name in for visits orderly when something opened.

Visits orderly.

That was the job.

Off the wing more.

Busy.

Trusted.

Something to break the day apart.

He had been talking about it for weeks.

One of the education staff had even said they'd put a decent word in if he kept going the way he was.

Jamo had gone back to the cell feeling like he had been offered parole.

Connor had laughed at him.

Not cruelly.

"You're excited about moving chairs for visits?"

"You don't understand."

"Clearly."

"Off the wing, mate. Different faces. Something to do."

Connor had nodded then.

He did understand that part.

Everybody understood wanting the day to move faster.

Jamo looked across the table now.

Connor was smiling at somebody else calling him Rush.

For the first time, Jamo wondered what Connor's new reputation might bring back to their cell.

Then he told himself not to be dramatic.

Connor had been back one day.

Nothing had happened.

Yet.

DARREN

Darren had slept in his clothes again.

Nobody knew that except Darren.

That was the point of prison clothes.

You could look like everybody else while quietly falling apart.

He sat on the edge of his bunk and listened to the wing waking up around him.

Doors.

Voices.

Someone shouting for an officer.

Somebody else shouting that the officer was ignoring him.

Same morning as yesterday.

Different amount of strength available for it.

Darren rubbed his face.

He felt hollow and heavy at the same time.

There were mornings when he promised himself he was done with everything.

There were afternoons when those promises became embarrassing.

He had stopped telling people.

People got bored of recovery stories when the same man kept appearing in the next chapter.

A knock came at the doorframe.

Darren looked up.

Officer Grant stood outside.

Grant did not lean into cells like some officers did.

He stood square in the doorway as if entering the space would give prisoners an advantage.

"Morning, Darren."

Darren hated when Grant used his first name.

It always sounded like paperwork.

"Sir."

"You look rough."

"Cheers."

Grant ignored the tone.

"Come see me later."

Darren's stomach tightened.

"What for?"

"Later."

"Am I in trouble?"

Grant looked at him.

"Should you be?"

Darren said nothing.

Grant walked away.

Darren stayed sitting on the bunk.

That was the problem with officers asking questions like that.

You could spend the next hour inventing reasons.

MALIK

By midday Malik had heard three new versions of Sunday's fight and two new versions of Connor.

In one, Connor had known Craig outside. False.

In another, Connor was already working for Craig before prison.

Also false.

The third claimed Connor's arrest had somehow been connected to Craig's conspiracy.

That one was so stupid Malik almost admired it.

"People are bored," he told Yusuf.

Yusuf was trying to repair the corner of a paperback with a strip of tape.

"People are always bored. That's why you exist."

"What does that mean?"

"You distribute nonsense professionally."

"I distribute information."

Yusuf looked up.

"Information with entertainment value."

"That's journalism."

Yusuf nodded.

"Exactly. You should ask for a press card."

Malik laughed.

Across the wing Connor walked past with Jamo.

Someone called Rush.

Connor turned.

Again.

Yusuf noticed.

"He likes it."

"Says he doesn't."

"That's how you know."

Malik watched Connor for another second.

"Could be good for him."

Yusuf went back to the book.

"Everything good for you in prison normally sends an invoice later."

Malik looked at him.

"You been talking to Mason?"

"No. I've just got eyes."

OFFICER MERCER

Mercer saw the change in Connor before Connor did.

It wasn't dramatic.

He had not started walking around like a gangster from a film.

Not yet.

It was smaller than that.

He was standing differently.

People greeting you did that.

People knowing your story did that.

A frightened new arrival spent his first days trying not to occupy too much space.

A young man who believed the wing approved of him started taking some back.

Mercer watched Connor laugh with two prisoners near the phones.

Craig was nowhere near him.

That interested her more.

Connor's new status was beginning to exist independently of Craig's physical presence.

That was how reputations became dangerous.

They stopped needing the original event.

"Blake."

Connor looked over.

"Miss."

"Don't look so pleased with yourself."

Connor glanced around theatrically.

"Wasn't."

"You were."

"Can't prove it."

Mercer almost smiled.

"Everything all right?"

"Yeah."

"Any problems since yesterday?"

"No."

That answer came quickly.

Too quickly perhaps, but Mercer let it go.

"Keep it that way."

Connor gave her a mock salute.

Mercer's expression changed.

Connor dropped his hand.

"Sorry."

"Good decision."

He walked off.

Mercer watched him join Jamo again.

Connor was learning.

The problem was that prison taught several lessons at once and rarely labelled which ones were useful.

DARREN - LATER

Grant made Darren wait outside the office.

Five minutes.

Then ten.

The waiting was deliberate.

Darren knew that because Grant opened the door twice, saw him and carried on doing something else.

Finally:

"In."

Darren stepped inside.

Grant remained standing.

"Sit."

Darren sat.

Grant looked at him for a moment.

"You know what happened Sunday."

It was not a question.

Darren shrugged.

"Everyone knows something."

"That's not what I asked."

"I heard there was a fight."

"You heard who was talking about it beforehand?"

Darren's body went still in a way he hoped Grant did not notice.

"No."

Grant smiled without warmth.

"You hear more than you think you do."

Darren stared at the desk.

"I don't get involved in all that."

"Good."

Grant leaned slightly closer.

"Then nobody has any reason to worry about you telling me what you happen to hear."

Darren looked up.

There it was.

Not an order.

Not quite.

Something worse.

An invitation designed to become an expectation later.

"I don't know nothing."

Grant held his gaze.

"Everybody knows something."

Darren said nothing.

Grant let the silence sit.

Then his tone changed.

"You having a difficult week?"

Darren almost laughed.

"What?"

"You look like you haven't slept."

"I'm fine."

"Course you are."

Grant opened the door.

"Off you go."

Darren stood.

He reached the doorway.

"Darren."

He turned.

Grant's voice was calm.

"If you remember anything useful, you know where I am."

Darren stepped back onto the wing.

The door shut behind him.

He immediately wished Grant had threatened him instead.

Threats were simpler.

CONNOR - NIGHT

Connor lay on the top bunk.

Jamo was below him talking about visits orderly again.

"I'm telling you, if that job comes up, I'm getting it."

Connor smiled at the ceiling.

"You said that yesterday."

"Manifesting."

"You don't know what manifesting means."

"Means I'm getting off this wing while you're still here cleaning toilets."

"Cells have toilets."

"Exactly. You'll have loads to choose from."

Connor laughed.

"I'm not cleaning nothing."

"Everyone works eventually."

"I'll get a proper job."

Jamo laughed from below.

"What's a proper job?"

Connor thought.

"Gym. Visits. Reception. Something where people trust you."

There was a pause.

Then Jamo said:

"You just got back from the block for jumping into Craig's fight."

Connor frowned.

"Wasn't his fight."

"That's exactly the sort of distinction security love."

Connor threw a sock down.

Jamo swore as it hit him.

"Prick."

Connor smiled.

He closed his eyes.

From somewhere farther along the wing came a shout.

"Rush!"

Connor opened one eye.

Jamo laughed below him.

"You love it."

"Do not."

"Course you don't."

Connor smiled in the dark.

That was the problem.

He did.

WEDNESDAY 2 OCTOBER 2019 - USEFUL

CONNOR - C WING

The first favour came disguised as a compliment.

Connor did not realise that until later.

At the time, all he heard was:

"You seem switched on."

He was standing near the phones waiting for Jamo, who had disappeared to chase an education officer about a form he had already submitted twice.

The man speaking to Connor was called Kez.

Connor knew that much.

Kez was older than him by enough years to seem established without seeming old. He had been around prison before, knew people on more than one wing and had a way of talking to new prisoners that made whatever he wanted sound like an opportunity they had been lucky enough to receive.

Jamo had described him with a sentence that somehow explained nothing.

He's all right, but just know what you're saying around him.

Connor had asked what that meant.

Jamo had replied, Exactly what I said.

Now Kez leaned against the wall as if the conversation had happened accidentally.

"Heard about Sunday."

Connor sighed.

"Everyone has."

"You did well."

Connor shrugged.

"Just happened."

"That's what people say when they want you to know they didn't shit themselves."

Connor laughed.

Kez smiled.

"No, seriously. Most people would've gone the other way."

Connor heard Craig's voice in the sentence.

Most people move the other way.

He liked hearing it from somebody else more than he should have.

"Wasn't thinking."

"Sometimes that's better."

Kez lowered his voice.

"You wanna make some money in here?"

Connor looked at him.

"Obviously."

"You wanna make a proper name for yourself?
Not just have Bruce give you one?"

That landed differently.

Connor smiled despite himself.

"What you talking about?"

Kez nodded like Connor had just passed a test.

"See? Switched on."

There it was again.

Kez made it sound like he was offering Connor a step upward rather than asking him to do something for Kez.

"People notice who's reliable," Kez said. "Do one thing properly, people remember. Then other things come."

Connor heard people remember.

He should have heard do one thing for me.

Kez looked down the landing.

"You got your family coming this week?"

Connor nodded.

"Tomorrow, hopefully."

"Good. This ain't that."

Connor's smile faded.

"What isn't?"

"Another visit. Not yet. Couple weeks, probably."

Connor frowned.

"With who?"

"Woman you don't know."

That should have ended the conversation.
Instead Connor stayed where he was.

Kez explained enough for Connor to understand the shape of the risk and deliberately left the rest feeling vague.

A woman connected to Kez's people would need to be added to Connor's approved visitor arrangements first. That meant forms, waiting and prison administration before anything could happen.

When the visit eventually came, she would bring something prohibited and Connor would be expected to take responsibility for getting it back onto the wing.

No method was discussed in detail.

Connor stared at Kez.

"You're serious?"

"Course."

"Why me?"

"Because no one's looking at you like that yet. And you've already shown you don't fold when something gets lively."

There it was.

Sunday repackaged and sold back to him.

Kez kept going.

"I'm telling you, Rush, you do something like this properly and people know you're sound. Money comes. People start trusting you. That's how you build yourself in here."

Connor heard opportunity.

Kez was describing usefulness.

But Connor did not know that yet.

He did not ask how much money.

He did not ask what Kez was making.

He did not ask how the split worked.

The money was almost secondary to the part Connor liked hearing: people start trusting you.

New prisoner.

Fresh reputation.

Eager to prove the story about Rush was real.

Connor thought about saying no.

Then he thought about Sunday.

About people greeting him differently.

About making money.

About making a name.

"Yeah," Connor said. "All right."

Kez clapped him lightly on the shoulder.

"Knew you were sound."

Connor watched him walk off.

His stomach had already started disagreeing with his mouth.

Two weeks suddenly felt both very far away and nowhere near far enough.

JAMO

Jamo came back carrying three pieces of paper and the expression of a man betrayed by government.

"They lost it."

Connor looked over.

"Lost what?"

"My visits orderly application."

"Again?"

"Apparently it 'isn't on the system.'"

Jamo made quotation marks with his fingers so aggressively Connor thought he might injure himself.

"I handed it to them."

"Maybe the system ate it."

"Don't."

"Hungry system."

"Connor."

Connor laughed.

Jamo dropped the papers onto the table.

"I've done another one. Education said they'll back me."

"You'll get it."

"You reckon?"

"Yeah."

Jamo looked suspicious.

"Why are you being nice?"

"Can't I be nice?"

"Not naturally."

Connor smiled.

Jamo sat opposite.

"You all right?"

"Yeah."

"You're doing that face."

"What face?"

"The one where you've agreed to something stupid."

Connor laughed too quickly.

"What are you on about?"

Jamo stared at him.

Connor looked away.

"Nothing."

"Who've you been talking to?"

"No one."

"Connor."

"Jamo."

"You're a shit liar."

Connor leaned back.

"Hear all. See all. Say nothing, remember?"

Jamo's face changed.

"That's not what Mason meant."

Connor smiled.

"You don't know that."

"I know he definitely didn't mean use it to hide stupid things from your padmate."

Connor got up.

"I'm getting tea."

"It's two in the afternoon."

"Early tea."

Jamo watched him walk away.

Then looked at the visits orderly application on the table.

For the first time, Connor's secrets were starting to feel as if they might become Jamo's problem too.

DARREN

Darren avoided Grant for most of the day.

Not dramatically.

He simply developed an intense interest in being wherever Grant wasn't.

Macca eventually noticed.

"You all right?"

"Yeah."

"You've been standing here five minutes while I moan about a phone."

"I'm listening."

"You never listen."

Darren shrugged.

"New me."

Macca looked past him.

Grant was walking onto the landing.

Macca looked back at Darren.

"Ah."

Darren frowned.

"What?"

"Nothing."

Grant called from farther down.

"Darren."

Darren's shoulders dropped.

"Apparently I exist. That's enough for him."

He walked toward Grant.

Grant's questions were vague enough that Darren could answer them without feeling like he had informed on anybody.

That was what Darren told himself.

"Malik knows everything," he said with a shrug.

Grant gave nothing away.

"Everybody says that."

"Then why ask me?"

"Because everybody sees different things."

Darren thought of Mason's phrase.

Hear all.

See all.

Say nothing.

Different teacher.

Different lesson.

BRUCE

Bruce had acquired a spoon.

This should not have been interesting.

It became interesting because Bruce was walking around asking everyone whether the spoon looked "institutional".

"It's a spoon," Yusuf said.

"That's not what I asked."

"What does institutional mean for a spoon?"

Bruce held it up to the light.

"Look at it. It's got no hope."

Yusuf stared at him.

Connor walked past.

Bruce pointed the spoon at him.

"Rush. Opinion."

"It's a spoon."

Bruce looked disappointed.

"Groupthink."

Connor laughed and carried on.

Bruce watched him go.

Then looked at Yusuf.

"He's doing something."

"Because of how he reviewed your spoon?"

"No. Because he's walking like his stomach's following him half a second later."

Yusuf looked after Connor.

"You are occasionally disturbingly observant."

Bruce put the spoon into his pocket.

"Ruins the brand if I do it too often."

CONNOR

By evening Connor had convinced himself the favour was a future problem.

That helped.

Not tomorrow.

Not even next week, probably.

There was paperwork first. Waiting. The woman had to be approved to visit him.

Plenty of time to change his mind.

He knew, even then, that this was probably a lie.

Craig found him near the end of association.

"You look busy."

Connor's stomach tightened.

"Do I?"

"No."

Connor stared at him.

Craig smiled slightly.

"That's why I said it."

They stood for a moment watching the wing.

"People treating you different?" Craig asked.

Connor shrugged.

"Bit."

"You like it?"

Connor looked away.

"Yeah. Bit."

Craig nodded.

No lecture.

No judgement.

Connor almost told him about Kez.

Then the thought embarrassed him.

What was he going to say?

Somebody offered me money and respect for something I haven't even done yet and I'm already nervous?

Rush wasn't nervous.

Connor was.

That distinction was becoming useful.

THURSDAY 3 OCTOBER 2019 - HOME

CONNOR

Visits made the prison feel briefly like the outside world had been brought indoors and told to behave itself.

Men who spent all week pretending not to care suddenly checked their hair in bits of reflective metal and asked each other whether their shirts looked all right.

Some talked too much beforehand.

Some went silent.

Macca had once told Connor there were only two kinds of prisoners on visit mornings: men pretending they weren't excited and liars.

Connor understood that now.

Today was his real visit.

His family.

Nothing to do with Kez.

The other visit was still sitting in the back of his mind like a date he wished he had never agreed to.

But when his name was called and he eventually saw his mum, that disappeared for a while.

Not completely.

Enough.

His mum looked smaller than Connor remembered.

That was impossible. He had been inside less than two weeks.

Still, prison had already started doing strange things to scale.

Rooms outside seemed bigger in memory. People seemed more fragile when you could not just go home with them.

His girlfriend was there too.

Connor smiled before he reached them.

His mum cried immediately.

"Mum."

"I'm fine."

"You're crying."

"I can cry and be fine."

"That doesn't sound right."

"Don't start."

Connor laughed.

For a few seconds they were almost normal.

Then came the questions.

Was he eating?

Was anyone bothering him?

Was the cell all right?

Had he spoken to his solicitor?

When would court be?

How long did he think he was going to get?

Connor answered the questions he could and lied gently around the ones he couldn't.

"Prison's boring more than anything."

That became his main line.

Boring sounded safe.

Boring did not contain Craig.

Boring did not contain the attack.

Boring did not contain a night in segregation
or a wing full of men now calling him Rush.

His girlfriend looked at him carefully.

"You look different."

Connor smiled.

"Been twelve days."

"Still."

"What, uglier?"

"Bit."

His mum told her off.

Connor laughed.

It felt good enough that for a moment he
forgot where he was.

Then an officer walked past and the room
snapped back into focus.

His mum told him his little brother kept
asking when Connor was coming home.

Connor looked down at the table.

"What'd you tell him?"

"That we don't know yet."

Connor nodded.

He hated the sentence because it was true.

"He drew you something."

His mum smiled through wet eyes.

"Apparently it's you in a Lamborghini."

Connor laughed.

"Obviously."

"You've got arms like a gorilla."

"Accurate."

His girlfriend smiled.

Connor did too.

Then his mum said:

"He's sleeping in your T-shirt."

Connor stopped smiling.

Not dramatically.

Just enough.

He pictured his little brother at home wearing something of Connor's because Connor himself was somewhere else.

For all the money Connor had told himself he made for family, none of it could put him back in that house tonight.

That thought sat with him for the rest of the visit.

When the visit ended, Connor hugged his mum longer than he meant to.

She whispered:

"Just come home the same person."

Connor nearly laughed because he had no idea how to answer that.

He had already been given another name.

Instead he said:

"I will."

His girlfriend hugged him next.

"Ring me."

"I will."

"Properly. Not one of your two-minute calls."

Connor smiled.

"All right."

He watched them leave.

That was the worst part of visits.

Not seeing people.

Watching them walk back into the life you had been removed from.

JAMO

Connor came back quieter than Jamo expected.

"Good visit?"

Connor nodded.

"Yeah."

"Mum cry?"

"Obviously."

"Girlfriend?"

"Didn't cry. Called me ugly though."

Jamo nodded.

"Healthy relationship."

Connor smiled.

Then went quiet again.

Jamo knew better than to fill every silence.

He lasted almost forty seconds.

"You all right?"

Connor looked at him.

"Yeah. Just weird seeing them go."

Jamo nodded.

That he understood.

After a moment he said:

"Your other stupid thing still happening?"

Connor's face changed.

Jamo pointed.

"There. That face."

"What face?"

"The one that says yes."

Connor looked away.

Jamo sighed.

"Don't bring bullshit back to this cell."

Connor nodded.

"I won't."

Neither of them knew yet how much weight that promise would end up carrying.

BRUCE

Bruce found Connor later.

"Family visit?"

"Yeah."

"Mum cry?"

Connor stared at him.

"Why does everyone ask that?"

"Mums cry. It's one of their main departments."

Connor laughed.

Bruce looked at him for a second.

"You look sad."

"Cheers."

"Not insultingly sad. Normal sad."

"That's better."

Bruce nodded.

"Good."

Then he walked away, apparently satisfied that he had completed an emotional welfare check.

Connor watched him go.

Bruce was the only person Connor knew who could make concern sound like a diagnosis from another planet.

FRIDAY 4 OCTOBER 2019 - IMPORTANT

CONNOR

Kez found Connor before breakfast.

"Your visitor thing's going in."

Connor knew exactly what he meant.

He hated that his stomach knew too.

"How long?"

Kez shrugged.

"However long they take. Couple weeks, maybe."

Connor nodded.

Kez smiled.

"Plenty of time for you to stop looking like you're about to confess to something."

Connor laughed despite himself.

"I'm fine."

"Course you are. That's why I asked you."

There it was again.

Kez never seemed to pressure Connor directly. He simply kept describing Connor as the sort of person who would obviously do what Kez wanted.

Reliable.

Switched on.

Not scared.

Making a name.

Connor found himself trying to live up to a description Kez had invented for him.

Kez walked off without mentioning money again.

Connor did not ask.

That would matter later.

JAMO

Jamo received news about visits orderly at eleven seventeen in the morning.

He knew the exact time because he had been staring at the clock during education when

somebody came to the door and asked for him.

For one glorious second he thought the job had come through.

Instead he was told there was still a delay with his application and some further checks needed completing.

"What checks?"

The answer contained enough words to sound official and not enough information to be useful.

Jamo came back to the wing furious.

Connor was near the phones laughing with Malik.

"What's happened?" Connor asked.

"Nothing. That's the problem."

Jamo explained.

Connor listened, then said the wrong thing.

"It'll sort itself."

Jamo stared at him.

"Will it?"

Connor shrugged.

"Probably."

"Easy for you to say."

"What does that mean?"

"Nothing."

Connor frowned.

Jamo had begun using nothing the way officers did: as a container for exactly the thing he did not want to say.

"Say it."

Jamo looked around the wing.

"You've been here two weeks and you've already got everyone knowing you. You don't need a job to get through the day."

Connor laughed once.

"What, you think being called Rush pays wages?"

"Didn't say that."

"Sounds like you did."

Jamo shook his head.

"Forget it."

He walked away.

Connor let him.

Five minutes later he regretted it.

Not enough to go after him.

That was the beginning of quite a few problems.

MASON

Mason saw Connor later on a movement and asked one question.

"You listening yet?"

Connor knew immediately what he meant.

"Hear all, see all, say nothing?"

"That's the one."

"Yeah."

Mason looked at him.

"You sure?"

Connor smiled.

"I hear loads."

"That's not the difficult bit."

Connor rolled his eyes.

Mason let him.

"Everybody thinks prison advice is about avoiding trouble," Mason said. "Half of it is about avoiding yourself."

Connor looked at him.

"That's deep for a Friday."

"I'll try being stupider tomorrow."

Connor laughed.

Mason walked on.

Connor watched him go and wondered why older prisoners always seemed happiest after saying something annoying.

DARREN

Grant asked Darren for one tiny thing.

That was how it started becoming normal.

Not names.

Not accusations.

Just whether a particular group had been unusually interested in who was moving between wings after the Craig incident.

Darren knew the answer.

He also knew everybody else probably knew it too.

So he told himself it didn't count.

"Jinx's lot have been talking about Rico," Darren said quietly.

Grant's face gave nothing away.

"Talking how?"

Darren immediately wished he had stopped one sentence earlier.

"Just talking."

Grant waited.

Darren hated waiting.

"They ain't happy with him, that's all."

Grant nodded.

"Right."

Darren sat back.

"That's not grassing. Everyone knows that."

Grant looked at him.

"I didn't call it anything."

That was worse.

Darren left the office thinking about the sentence he had said to Grant and the sentence Grant had not said back.

On the landing Malik passed him.

"You all right?"

Darren nodded too fast.

"Yeah."

Malik kept walking.

Darren watched him go.

In prison, a guilty conscience could turn every normal question into an interrogation.

BRUCE

Bruce was attempting to convince Yusuf that Friday had a different smell from Thursday.

"It doesn't."

"It does."

"What does Friday smell like?"

Bruce thought hard.

"Expectation and old chips."

Yusuf stared at him.

"And Thursday?"

"Administrative sadness."

Connor walked past.

Yusuf pointed at Bruce.

"Help me."

Connor shook his head.

"No chance."

Bruce looked at Connor.

"You look medium-haunted."

"Cheers."

"Not urgent haunting. Scheduled haunting."

Connor laughed.

Bruce tilted his head.

"Something coming up?"

Connor stopped.

"Why?"

"Your face looks like it's waiting for an appointment letter."

Connor stared at him.

Yusuf started laughing.

Bruce raised both hands.

"I'm just saying."

Connor walked off.

Bruce watched him go.

"Definitely got future trouble."

Yusuf shook his head.

"You are occasionally disturbingly observant."

"Ruins the brand if I do it too often."

SUNDAY 6 OCTOBER 2019 - THE SPIN

CONNOR - C WING

The officers arrived at the cell while Connor and Jamo were both out.

That was almost worse.

By the time Connor came back, two staff were inside and half the contents of the cell seemed to have migrated into places they had never chosen to live.

Mattress shifted.

Clothes moved.

Books stacked differently.

Property checked.

Jamo stood outside the door with his jaw clenched.

"What's this about?" Connor asked.

One officer barely looked up.

"Routine search."

Jamo laughed once.

It was not a happy laugh.

"Routine. Course it is."

Connor looked at him.

Jamo looked back.

The dangerous visit had not happened. The unknown woman was not even approved yet.

That almost made the search worse in a different way.

Connor had already acquired enough attention for Jamo to wonder whether every knock at the door had something to do with him.

A search turned ordinary possessions into evidence simply by touching them.

Connor watched one officer check a shoebox.

Jamo saw him watching.

"Happy now?" Jamo said quietly.

Connor frowned.

"What?"

"This is what I was talking about."

"They said routine."

"And you believe that?"

Connor lowered his voice.

"There's nothing here."

"That's not the fucking point."

An officer looked over.

"Language."

Jamo turned.

"Sorry, sir. Would you prefer I politely thank you for turning the cell upside down?"

Connor closed his eyes for half a second.

Wrong sentence.

The officer stepped toward Jamo.

"Want to change your attitude?"

Jamo's face said no.

His mouth almost agreed.

Connor cut in.

"Leave it, mate."

Jamo looked at him sharply.

That made things worse.

"Don't tell me to leave it."

"I'm trying to help."

"You've helped enough."

The words landed.

Connor stopped speaking.

JAMO

There were no dramatic discoveries.

That should have made Jamo feel better.

Instead, by the time staff left, his whole day had been ruined.

His bedding was wrong.

His books were wrong.

His papers were mixed.

One of his education sheets had been folded through the middle.

Stupid things.

Tiny things.

Exactly the sort of things prison made enormous because they were among the few things a prisoner could arrange for himself.

Connor began putting clothes back.

"I'll sort it."

Jamo stared at him.

"You think that's the problem?"

Connor stopped.

"I said I'll sort it."

"I don't want you sorting it. I want you not bringing bullshit to the door."

"You don't even know this was me."

"Neither do you."

Connor's expression hardened.

"Nothing got found."

"Again: not the point."

Jamo picked up his paperwork.

"I've got an education review tomorrow. I'm trying to get visits. I'm trying to do my

sentence without being involved in everyone else's crap."

Connor felt accused of more than the search.

"I didn't ask you to get involved."

Jamo laughed.

"We share a cell, you idiot. I don't get a vote."

Silence.

Connor looked at the floor.

Jamo instantly knew he had gone a little too far.

He also knew he meant it.

That was the problem.

"Just... think," Jamo said, quieter.

Connor looked up.

"I do think."

Jamo gave him a look.

Connor almost smiled.

Almost.

"Sometimes," Connor added.

Jamo's mouth twitched.

The argument did not disappear.

But neither did the friendship.

Not yet.

OFFICER MERCER

Mercer heard about the search because Connor asked her whether it had been targeted.

"I'm not discussing security decisions with you."

Connor sighed.

"That means yes."

"No, it means exactly what I said."

"Jamo thinks it was because of me."

Mercer looked at him.

"Was there a reason it might've been?"

Connor hesitated.

One beat too long.

Mercer noticed.

Connor noticed her noticing.

"No."

"Right."

"Why'd you say it like that?"

"Like what?"

"Like you don't believe me."

"Blake, I have several things to do today. Managing your facial expressions isn't one of them."

Connor smiled despite himself.

Then it faded.

"Can something like that mess up his job?"

Mercer's tone changed slightly.

"A search by itself doesn't automatically decide somebody's future. But if he wants trusted work, he needs to keep his own record clean and stay away from unnecessary problems."

Connor looked back toward the cell.

"He has."

"Then maybe help him continue doing that."

Connor disliked the sentence because it sounded suspiciously like responsibility.

MASON

Mason found Jamo later carrying a bundle of education papers.

"Face like thunder."

"Got spun."

"Anything found?"

"No."

"Then what's the face for?"

Jamo stared at him.

Mason smiled.

"I'm joking."

"Funny."

"You're young. You'll appreciate me later."

"I'm twenty-three."

"Exactly. Newborn."

Jamo shook his head.

Mason looked at the papers.

"Visits job?"

"Trying."

"Keep trying."

Jamo hesitated.

"You reckon sharing with someone can mess you up?"

Mason knew who he meant without asking.

"Sometimes."

Jamo waited.

"That's it?"

"You want me to tell you Connor's either good or bad for you?"

"Would be useful."

"Then ask somebody who likes lying."

Jamo sighed.

Mason nodded toward the papers.

"Your sentence is yours. Don't hand it to your padmate because you're annoyed with him."

Jamo frowned.

"What's that mean?"

"Means if you want visits orderly, keep doing what gets you there. Don't start collecting trouble because somebody else already has a nickname."

Jamo looked away.

Mason smiled faintly.

"See? You lot think I only talk in riddles because it makes me feel old."

"Does it?"

"Massively."

CONNOR - NIGHT

The cell was quieter than normal.

Jamo read.

Connor stared at the television.

The signal cut out halfway through something neither had been properly watching.

The screen froze.

Jamo looked up.

Connor looked at him.

Then both started laughing.

Not because it was funny.

Because prison had chosen the exact moment of maximum tension to remove the one thing stopping them from talking.

"Fucking place," Jamo said.

Connor nodded.

"I'll stay out your way with stupid shit."

Jamo looked at him.

Connor kept his eyes on the frozen screen.

"I mean it."

Jamo was quiet for a moment.

"All right."

Connor glanced down.

"You still gonna get visits?"

"Obviously."

"Even with your attitude?"

"Especially with my attitude. They need character."

Connor smiled.

For the moment, that was enough.

TUESDAY 8 OCTOBER 2019 - WING CLEANER

CONNOR

Connor discovered his employment prospects were less glamorous than his prison reputation.

The officer behind the desk looked at the sheet.

"Wing cleaner."

Connor waited.

The officer looked up.

"That's your job."

"What about gym?"

"No."

"Visits?"

"No."

"Reception?"

"Definitely no."

Connor frowned.

"Why definitely?"

The officer gave him a look that seemed to contain Sunday's fight, segregation, Craig, the search and several things Connor did not know staff knew.

"Because those are trusted positions."

"And I'm not trusted?"

"You're new, you're on remand and you've already attracted security attention."

Connor leaned back.

"I didn't start the fight."

"Didn't say you did."

"So why am I getting punished?"

"You're not. You've been allocated work."

Connor looked at the cleaning sheet.

Prison had a special talent for making punishment and opportunity share handwriting.

"Wing cleaner," he repeated.

"Correct."

"Cleaning the wing."

"You're catching on."

Connor stared at him.

"Any more questions?"

"Loads. None you're gonna answer."

The officer smiled despite himself.

"Good. Start tomorrow."

BRUCE

Bruce took the news harder than Connor.

"No."

Connor looked at him.

"What do you mean, no?"

"Rush can't be a cleaner."

"Apparently Rush can."

Bruce shook his head.

"Destroys the mythology."

Yusuf was sitting nearby with tea.

"What mythology?"

Bruce pointed at Connor.

"Man survives attempted assassination politics and gets assigned a squeegee."

Connor laughed.

"Wasn't an assassination."

"Exactly. Even the story's shrinking."

Yusuf nodded thoughtfully.

"Could rebrand him."

Connor looked suspicious.

"Don't."

Bruce's eyes brightened.

"Mopfather."

Connor walked away.

Yusuf nearly choked on his drink.

Bruce shouted after him:

"It's got range!"

CONNOR - FIRST SHIFT

The next morning Connor learned three things about wing cleaning.

First: everybody noticed dirt only after he had walked past it.

Second: prisoners who would never clean their own cell had passionate views about how the landing should be cleaned.

Third: officers could find one dry patch on a wet floor from fifty yards away.

"Blake."

Connor turned with the mop in his hand.

"Yeah?"

"You've missed that corner."

Connor looked at the corner.

It looked exactly like every other corner.

"Have I?"

"Yes."

Connor looked back at the officer.

"How can you tell?"

"Because it's dirty."

"They're all dirty. It's prison."

The officer pointed.

Connor sighed and went back.

From a cell doorway Bruce applauded slowly.

"Rise of an empire."

"Get fucked."

"Language on duty."

Connor threw a cloth at him.

Bruce dodged it.

"Workplace violence!"

For all the humiliation Connor performed about it, the job did something useful.

It gave him a reason to move.

He learned who woke early.

Who stayed behind their door until forced out.

Who was neat.

Who lived in chaos.

Who talked to officers like people and who only spoke to them when angry.

Who gave him a tea while he cleaned nearby.

Who expected him to clear up after them as if being called Rush somehow included domestic service.

He learned prison from floor level.

Mason would have enjoyed that thought.

Connor refused to give it to him.

LEON

Leon watched Connor cleaning near the stairs after gym.

"How's the career?"

Connor looked up.

"Flying."

Leon nodded at the mop.

"Management next."

"Don't you start. Bruce has been unbearable."

"Bruce is unbearable recreationally."

Connor smiled.

Leon adjusted the small pile of gym paperwork he was carrying.

Connor nodded toward it.

"How'd you get gym?"

"Kept my head down. Trained. Didn't involve myself in other people's business."

Connor stared at him.

Leon smiled.

"You asked."

"Everyone's a fucking life coach this week."

"Maybe the universe thinks you need one."

"Universe needs to mind its business."

Leon laughed and walked on.

Connor looked at the mop.

He had wanted a trusted job because trusted sounded like status.

Instead, his reputation among prisoners was beginning to make staff trust him less.

That contradiction sat badly with him.

It was the first concrete thing Rush had cost him.

Not enough to make him dislike the name.

But enough to make him notice the bill.

JAMO

Jamo found Connor near the end of the shift, sweating and annoyed.

"All right, Mopfather?"

Connor stared at him.

"Bruce told you."

"Bruce told everyone."

"I'm gonna kill him."

"That'll help with trusted jobs."

Connor laughed despite himself.

Jamo leaned on the rail.

"Got another meeting Thursday about visits."

Connor looked up.

"Serious?"

"Yeah."

"You'll get it."

Jamo shrugged, trying to look less hopeful than he was.

Connor saw through it.

"You really want this, don't you?"

"Mate, I want a reason not to know what you're doing all day."

Connor smiled.

"Fair."

Jamo looked at the cleaning trolley.

"Need a hand?"

Connor frowned.

"You offering to clean?"

"No. Just wanted to hear how desperate you were."

Connor flipped him off.

Jamo walked away laughing.

The crack between them was still small enough to joke across.

THURSDAY 10 OCTOBER 2019 - DARREN

DARREN

Darren knew exactly how bad he looked because people had started telling him.

Not cruelly.

That was worse.

"You all right, Daz?"

"You look rough, mate."

"Get some sleep."

"You eating?"

Concern made deterioration official.

Darren preferred jokes.

Jokes meant people could still pretend nothing serious was happening.

He stood at the servery waiting for food and realised he had forgotten what day it was.

"Thursday," Macca said beside him.

Darren looked over.

"What?"

"You just asked what day it is."

"Did I?"

"Yeah."

Darren rubbed his face.

"Long week."

Macca looked at him for a second.

"They're all long weeks when you're awake for all of them."

Darren smiled.

"That's almost wise."

"Don't tell Mason. He'll sue."

The line moved.

Darren took his tray.

For the next twenty minutes he managed to feel normal.

That was often how prison worked.

You could be falling apart at nine, arguing about potatoes at nine-ten and laughing at Bruce by half past.

OFFICER GRANT

Grant did not think of Darren as vulnerable.

He thought of him as available.

There was a difference, at least in Grant's mind.

Prisoners talked constantly about loyalty until the moment their own comfort was threatened. Officers who refused to understand that, Grant believed, were sentimental.

He had seen too many assaults happen after everybody on a wing supposedly knew nothing.

Too many phones appear from nowhere.

Too many men suddenly become deaf when asked a straightforward question.

Information prevented problems.

That was what he told himself.

Darren sat opposite him again.

"Why do you keep calling me in here?"

"Because you keep coming."

Darren gave him a tired look.

"You call my name over the landing."

"And you could refuse."

Darren laughed without humour.

"Yeah. Brilliant idea."

Grant leaned back.

"Relax."

Darren hated that word.

"I am relaxed."

"You look terrible."

"Everyone's a doctor this week."

Grant let the silence stretch.

Then:

"Who is Kez spending time with?"

Darren's stomach tightened.

He looked at Grant.

"Why?"

"Just asking."

Darren almost laughed at the familiarity of the phrase.

It sounded like every prisoner who had ever wanted something without admitting it.

"I don't know."

"You do."

"He's on the wing. He talks to people."

"Including Blake?"

Darren looked down.

There it was.

Connor.

Rush.

The visit.

Darren had heard bits.

Everybody had heard bits.

He said nothing.

Grant watched him.

"Good," Grant said.

Darren looked up.

"What?"

"Nothing."

Grant opened a drawer, took out a form and began reading it as if Darren had disappeared.

Darren sat there another ten seconds.

"Can I go?"

"Yep."

Darren stood.

He had given Grant nothing.

That should have felt like a win.

Instead, the fact Grant had asked made Connor's visit suddenly feel bigger.

CONNOR

Connor was cleaning outside Darren's cell when Darren came back.

"All right?"

Darren nodded.

"Yeah."

Connor looked at him.

"You look fucked."

"Cheers, Rush."

"Don't call me that when I'm holding a mop."

Darren smiled.

"Why?"

"Ruins the brand."

"Brand was shaky already."

Connor laughed.

Darren stepped into the cell, then stopped.

"You know Grant's asking about you?"

Connor's smile vanished.

"What?"

Darren immediately regretted saying it.

"Not you exactly. Kez. People around Kez."

Connor looked down the landing.

"Why's he asking you?"

The question was innocent.

Darren heard accusation anyway.

"He asks everyone stuff."

Connor looked back.

"Does he?"

Darren shrugged.

"He's a prick."

Connor accepted that because it was easy to accept.

"Cheers for telling me."

Darren nodded.

Connor moved on with the cleaning trolley.

Darren stood in his doorway.

He had warned Connor.

That made him feel better.

Then he realised he had also revealed that Grant had been questioning him.

That made him feel worse.

There was no clean direction anymore.

MALIK

Malik noticed Darren watching people.

Not in the ordinary prison way.

Everybody watched everybody.

Darren was watching and then looking guilty about having watched.

That was different.

Malik sat beside Yusuf.

"Darren's acting weird."

Yusuf did not look up from his book.

"Darren's always acting weird."

"Different weird."

"Specify."

"Like he's got something on his mind."

Yusuf finally looked at him.

"Could be his life."

Malik frowned.

"Helpful."

"You're welcome."

Across the wing Grant called another prisoner's name.

Darren flinched even though it wasn't his.

Malik saw it.

Yusuf saw Malik see it.

"Don't," Yusuf said.

"Don't what?"

"Turn him into a mystery because you're bored."

Malik looked at him.

"I don't do that."

Yusuf raised an eyebrow.

Malik sighed.

"Fine. Sometimes."

"Hear all."

Malik rolled his eyes.

"Don't start."

"See all."

"Yusuf."

"And maybe shut up occasionally."

Malik smiled.

"Mason's line is better."

"Mason's older. He's had time to edit."

DARREN - NIGHT

At night Darren lay awake listening to the cell around him.

The plumbing.

A television through a wall.

Someone shouting something impossible to understand two landings away.

His own thoughts.

Those were loudest.

He had not always been this version of himself.

That was something people forgot.

There had been jobs.

A girlfriend once.

A period where he had gone months without touching anything and genuinely believed the difficult part was over.

Then another arrest.

Another sentence.

Another bad week.

Another promise he would stop tomorrow.

Prison reduced time into units small enough to betray yourself with.

Get through the morning.

Get through bang-up.

Get through tonight.

Tomorrow could be better.

Tomorrow was useful because it never arrived as tomorrow.

It always arrived as today, which could be ruined immediately.

Darren closed his eyes.

Somewhere on the wing somebody shouted:

"Darren's bang on the spice these days."

Laughter followed.

Darren opened his eyes.

He did not know whether the voice was joking.

He did not know whether the laughter was at him.

He stared into the dark.

That was how reputations worked in prison.

Connor got Rush.

Darren got Darren.

Sometimes your own name became the story.

SATURDAY 12 OCTOBER 2019 - OTHER PEOPLE'S DAYS

MACCA

Macca had been waiting for the call all morning.

Not a casual call.

Not one of the five-minute conversations where everybody says they're fine because there isn't enough time to admit otherwise.

His daughter's birthday was tomorrow.

He wanted to speak to her before the house filled with people and noise and somebody inevitably put him on speakerphone like prison was a family attraction.

At ten thirty, the wing locked down.

Nobody told him why.

That was prison's favourite kind of reason.

"What's happening?" Macca called through the door.

No answer.

Ten minutes later he tried again.

"Boss! I need the phone!"

Somewhere down the landing an officer shouted back:

"Everyone's locked up."

"I can see that! Why?"

No answer.

Macca sat on the edge of the bunk.

He looked at the clock.

Ten forty-three.

At ten forty-five his daughter would probably be going out with her mum.

He had built his entire morning around a phone call prison had erased without explanation.

He hit the mattress with the flat of his hand.

Not hard.

Just enough to give the anger somewhere physical to go.

Outside, whatever had caused the lockdown probably felt important to somebody.

Inside Macca's cell, nothing in the prison mattered more than a twelve-year-old girl who might think her dad had forgotten.

LEON

Leon lost his gym session.

Normally he accepted cancellations because there was no point doing anything else.

Today he did not.

"We were already down there."

The officer looked tired.

"And now you're not."

"Helpful."

"Glad to be of service."

Leon exhaled through his nose.

He had arranged the entire day around training.

Food before.

Shower after.

Reading in the afternoon.

Prison took control in small pieces. Leon fought back by putting the pieces he had left into an order.

A lockdown was not just a missed gym session.

It was somebody else reaching into his day and shaking it.

Bruce, locked two doors away, shouted:

"Leon!"

"What?"

"Do press-ups emotionally!"

Leon stared at his door.

"What does that mean?"

"No idea. Keep moving!"

Leon laughed despite himself.

Routine damaged.

Not destroyed.

That mattered.

JINX - A WING

The lockdown had started because of trouble nobody on A Wing understood properly.

That did not stop everybody having a version.

Rico had been moved somewhere else after the Craig incident and people were still arguing about what that meant.

Some said he'd been threatened.

Some said staff were keeping him separate.

Some said people outside were angry.

Jinx believed about thirty percent of everything and trusted none of the percentages.

Deano appeared during the first movement after the doors finally opened.

"This your lot?"

Jinx looked at him.

"Morning to you too."

"I'm asking."

"And I'm saying don't call every bit of trouble my lot."

Deano folded his arms.

"People are saying Rico's still causing noise."

"People say Bruce used to be a jockey."

"Was he?"

Jinx stared at him.

Deano smiled.

"See? Now I'm interested."

Jinx shook his head.

"Whatever happened today, it ain't me."

Deano's expression hardened slightly.

"Good. Keep it that way."

"You giving orders now?"

"No. I'm asking nicely before all this Craig shit becomes everybody's problem."

Jinx looked at him.

For once, he agreed.

He did not enjoy that either.

OFFICER BENNETT

Bennett's phone vibrated in his pocket after shift.

He did not look at it immediately.

That had become a ritual.

If he didn't look, the message did not exist for another thirty seconds.

He got to the car park.

Sat in his car.

Finally checked.

Three words.

Need you Monday.

No threat.

No explanation.

The lack of both made his chest tighten.

Bennett locked the phone and stared through the windscreen.

At work he had spent the morning helping manage a lockdown caused by somebody else's problem.

Now he was off shift and still inside a different one.

He started the car.

For the first time, home did not feel like leaving prison.

CONNOR

Connor spent part of the lockdown cleaning a section of landing he had already cleaned.

"Why am I cleaning if everyone's behind their door?"

The officer shrugged.

"Because you're a cleaner."

"But nobody can even see the clean bit."

"I can."

Connor looked at him.

"That's worse."

The officer pointed to the bucket.

Connor sighed.

When the doors finally opened, Macca came out furious.

"Missed my call."

Connor looked up.

"What call?"

"My daughter."

The anger in Macca's voice changed the room.

Connor put the mop down.

"Birthday thing?"

Macca nodded.

Connor remembered because Macca had mentioned it about fourteen times.

"Can you ring later?"

"Yeah. Maybe. That's not the point."

Connor almost said nothing you can do about it.

Then he remembered how many times people had said versions of that to him since arrest.

He didn't.

"Hope you get through," he said instead.

Macca looked at him.

"Cheers."

A minute later Leon came past complaining about gym.

Jamo appeared angry because education had been cancelled.

Darren looked terrible because he'd spent too long locked in his cell with himself.

Malik had six different explanations for why the doors had shut.

Bruce claimed it was "institutional weather."

Connor looked around.

Same lockdown.

Six different disasters.

Mason's phrase came back again.

Hear all.

See all.

Say nothing.

Connor was starting to understand the first two.

MONDAY 14 OCTOBER 2019 - JOSH

DARREN

Darren noticed Josh because Josh had been on the wing approximately six minutes and had already asked nine questions.

"Where's showers?"

"Other end."

"Gym?"

"Not now."

"Canteen day?"

"Depends when your account's sorted."

"How long's that take?"

"How long's a piece of string?"

Josh frowned.

"Depends how long the string is."

Darren stared at him.

Josh stared back.

Then Darren laughed.

"You're gonna be hard work, you are."

Josh grinned.

"Everyone says that."

He was young enough that the prison clothes looked borrowed.

Not physically too big or too small.

Just wrong on him somehow.

Like he should have been wearing trainers and a coat, talking too loudly on a bus somewhere.

Instead he was standing on C Wing carrying property and trying to understand an entire institution in one afternoon.

Darren recognised the panic underneath the energy.

Most people would not.

He had seen enough first nights to know that some men went quiet when frightened and others became twice as loud.

Josh seemed to have chosen speed.

"What's your name?" Darren asked.

"Josh. You?"

"Darren."

"People calling you Daz?"

"Some."

"I'll call you Daz."

"Will you?"

"Yeah. Darren sounds like you've done something wrong."

Darren laughed again.

It had been a while since someone made him laugh without trying to cheer him up.

JOSH

Josh had expected prison to look more like prison.

He could not explain what that meant.

Maybe darker.

Maybe quieter.

Maybe everyone staring at him permanently.

Instead people were arguing about toast.

A cleaner was pushing a trolley.

Somebody was trying to borrow a pen.

A ginger bloke was telling another man that pigeons were "outside informants with wings."

Josh had been terrified all morning.

Now he was mostly confused.

The cleaner looked about his age.

"All right?" the cleaner said.

"Yeah. You?"

"Living the dream."

Josh looked at the mop.

"This the dream?"

The cleaner smiled.

"Apparently. Connor."

"Josh."

Someone farther down shouted:

"Rush!"

Connor turned automatically.

Josh looked between him and the voice.

"Thought you said Connor."

"I did."

"Who's Rush?"

Connor sighed.

"Unfortunately, also me."

Josh brightened.

"How'd you get a nickname already?"

"Long story."

Bruce appeared from nowhere.

"I named him."

Josh looked at Bruce.

"Why?"

"Public service."

"What's your name?"

"Bruce."

Josh waited.

"That's it?"

Bruce looked offended.

"Bruce is already a nickname if you commit to it hard enough."

Josh laughed so loudly two men looked over.

Connor shook his head.

"Don't encourage him."

"Too late," Bruce said. "New one's got excellent judgement."

DARREN - LATER

Darren found Josh trying to make his bed.

Trying was generous.

The sheet had become a philosophical problem.

"How've you done that?"

Josh looked up.

"Done what?"

"Made a rectangle complicated."

"Mattress is shit."

"Mattress has been a mattress longer than you've been alive. It knows what it's doing."

Josh laughed.

Darren helped him straighten it without making a big thing of helping.

"What you in for?" Darren asked.

Josh shrugged.

"Car thing."

"Car thing?"

"Yeah. Took a motor. Stupid."

"Yours?"

Josh looked at him.

"If it was mine, I wouldn't be here, would I?"

Darren smiled.

"Fair."

Josh sat on the bunk, immediately stood again, then sat back down as if his body had changed its mind.

"I'm not like some proper criminal though."

Darren looked at him.

"You're in prison saying that."

"Yeah, but you know what I mean."

Darren did.

Everybody had a version of themselves that explained why they were not really one of the people around them.

Darren had used several.

Josh looked toward the door.

"How long you been here?"

"Long enough."

"What's the worst bit?"

Darren thought.

Josh leaned forward, waiting.

"Boredom," Darren said.

Josh looked genuinely offended.

"Seriously?"

"Seriously."

"That's shit."

"Welcome to prison."

MACCA

Josh met Macca because he interrupted him on the phone.

Not deliberately.

Josh simply saw Darren and walked over while Darren happened to be standing near Macca.

"Daz, is canteen-"

Macca turned.

The look stopped Josh mid-sentence.

"Sorry."

Macca pointed at the phone.

Josh nodded rapidly.

"Yep. Sorry. Sorry, mate."

He backed away.

Darren followed him.

"Rule one," Darren said. "Don't interrupt Macca when he's on the phone."

"How was I meant to know?"

"He's holding a phone."

"Yeah, but loads of people hold phones."

"Rule two: don't argue with rule one."

Josh laughed.

Macca finished his call and came over a few minutes later.

Josh looked nervous.

"Sorry, mate."

Macca stared at him.

Then smiled.

"You're new."

"Can tell?"

"You apologised."

Darren laughed.

Josh looked between them.

"Is everyone a comedian in here?"

Macca nodded toward Bruce.

"No. Some are medical conditions."

Bruce, despite being too far away to hear properly, raised a hand.

"Love you too."

Josh burst out laughing again.

DARREN - NIGHT

By bang-up Josh had asked Darren where the gym was twice, when canteen came three times, whether enhanced was worth getting, whether the food improved on weekends, whether officers could read legal mail, whether the TV channels were always this bad and whether anyone had ever escaped from Lewes.

Darren answered some.

Ignored some.

Made up one answer about the television just to see whether Josh would believe him.

He did.

Darren corrected it before the lie could travel.

"Why you helping me?" Josh asked eventually.

Darren was standing at the cell door.

"Am I?"

"Yeah."

Darren shrugged.

"Someone helped me."

That was not entirely true.

Several people had helped him badly.

But Josh did not need that version yet.

"Night, Daz."

"Night, mate."

Darren walked back toward his own cell.

For the first time in weeks, he realised he had gone almost an hour without thinking about Grant.

Or drugs.

Or himself.

Someone else had needed him.

It felt good.

That would matter later.

THURSDAY 17 OCTOBER 2019 - SOMEBODY KNOWS SOMETHING

JOSH

Josh had been on C Wing three days and had already decided Darren knew everything.

This was not true.

Darren knew enough to look impressive to somebody who knew nothing.

That was different.

"What happens if they lose your canteen?"

"You complain."

"Then what?"

"You complain again."

"Then what?"

"You become old."

Josh laughed.

They were standing near the servery while Connor worked around them with the cleaning trolley.

"Daz," Connor said, "tell your child to move."

Josh looked around.

"Who?"

"You."

"I'm not his child."

Darren looked at Connor.

"Can you stop bullying my son?"

Connor shook his head.

"Three days. You've adopted him in three days."

Josh grinned.

"He likes me."

"I tolerate you," Darren said.

"Same thing in prison."

Connor pointed at him.

"That's actually true."

Josh looked pleased with himself.

DARREN

Josh's energy made ordinary things feel new again.

Canteen arrived and Josh reacted as if Christmas had been delivered in a plastic bag.

"Look at this."

Darren looked.

"I've seen noodles before."

"Yeah, but they're mine."

"Congratulations."

"And biscuits."

"Steady."

Josh laughed and immediately started planning what he was going to buy the following week.

Darren watched him.

There was something almost painful about how quickly new prisoners learned to shrink their excitement down to prison-sized things.

A decent meal.

A letter.

A phone call.

Gym.

A parcel arriving.

The television working.

Darren remembered his first canteen.

He remembered being happy about coffee.

Then he remembered too much else and stopped.

"You all right?" Josh asked.

Darren looked up.

"Yeah."

Josh accepted the answer instantly.

That innocence around prison answers would not last.

OFFICER GRANT

Grant waited until Josh had moved away before calling Darren.

Darren noticed.

That alone made him angry.

"What?"

Grant looked at him.

"Office."

"I'm busy."

"Doing what?"

Darren glanced toward Josh, who was still organising his canteen as if preparing for a shop display.

"Stuff."

Grant's expression did not change.

"Office."

Darren followed.

Inside, Grant closed the door.

"Who's the new lad?"

Darren's chest tightened.

"Josh."

"Know him outside?"

"No."

"Then why's he following you?"

Darren shrugged.

"He's new."

Grant nodded.

"Keep him out of trouble."

Darren looked suspicious.

"Why do you care?"

"Because that's my job."

Darren almost laughed.

Grant continued.

"And while you're being helpful, tell me what people are saying about Kez."

There it was.

Darren looked away.

"Nothing."

"Nothing?"

"Nothing useful."

Grant leaned back.

"You were happy enough to talk last week."

Darren felt the trap close around a sentence he had barely noticed saying.

"I didn't tell you anything."

"Didn't you?"

Darren stared at him.

Grant did not need to threaten him.

He simply let Darren remember.

Rico.

Jinx's lot.

Kez.

Little bits.

Harmless bits.

Things everybody knew.

That was how Darren had described them.

Now they sat together in his head like a file.

"I ain't a grass," Darren said.

Grant's face remained calm.

"I didn't say you were."

"Stop saying that."

"Saying what?"

"That you didn't say things."

Grant almost smiled.

"Go back to the wing, Darren."

Darren stood.

At the door Grant added:

"You're doing better than you think."

Darren turned.

"At what?"

Grant did not answer.

Darren hated him for that more than if he had.

JAMO

Jamo had his visits-orderly meeting postponed again.

This time the reason was not a lost form.

The officer told him there were concerns around recent association and wing

intelligence and that his application would remain under review.

Jamo stared at him.

"Association with who?"

The officer did not name anyone.

He did not need to.

Jamo walked back to the cell with his face burning.

Connor was inside folding clothes badly.

"How'd it go?"

Jamo put the paperwork down.

"Didn't."

Connor looked up.

"What happened?"

"Still under review."

"Why?"

Jamo laughed.

Connor heard the answer before he got it.

"They're saying association concerns."

Silence.

Connor put the shirt down.

"That could mean anything."

"Yeah. Funny how it started meaning anything after you arrived."

Connor's expression changed.

"Don't blame me for everything."

"I'm not."

"Sounds like you are."

Jamo looked at him.

"I did six months clean. Education every week. No nickings. No bullshit. I share a cell with you for three weeks and suddenly I'm a concern."

Connor stood.

"I didn't ask them to do that."

"I know."

"Then what do you want me to do?"

Jamo opened his mouth.

Nothing came out.

That was the worst part.

There was nothing Connor could do.

The unfairness needed a person to attach itself to anyway.

Connor was standing right there.

"Forget it," Jamo said.

He left the cell.

Connor watched him go.

This time he did not follow.

KEZ

Kez caught Connor near the stairs later that afternoon.

"Saturday."

Connor stopped.

For a second he genuinely did not know what Kez meant.

Then the two weeks collapsed all at once.

"She's on?"

"Approved. Visit's booked."

Connor nodded slowly.

Kez smiled.

"Told you. Easy money."

Connor looked at him.

"You never said how much."

Kez was already turning away.

"You'll be looked after."

"Kez."

Kez glanced back.

"What?"

Connor nearly asked.

How much?

What are you getting?

What exactly am I doing this for?

Instead he heard his own pride answer first.

"Nothing."

Kez smiled.

"That's why I like you, Rush. Don't overthink everything."

Then he walked away.

Connor stood there feeling, for the first time, that perhaps overthinking it would have been the cleverer option.

JOSH

Josh found Darren afterwards and immediately began telling him a story about a teacher who had once tried to stop him leaving class and accidentally locked herself outside instead.

The story took six minutes because Josh kept adding details that were not necessary.

Darren laughed twice.

By the end, he was properly smiling.

"You're full of shit," Darren said.

"It's true."

"No chance."

"Swear down. Ask my mum."

Darren shook his head.

Josh looked at him.

"You got kids?"

The question landed differently from everything else.

Darren's smile faded.

"No."

"Want them?"

"Mate, you've known me three days."

Josh shrugged.

"I'm efficient."

Darren laughed again.

"Go annoy someone else."

Josh stood.

"You love me really."

"Deeply. Now fuck off."

Josh went.

Darren watched him cross the wing.

He thought about Grant asking who Josh was.

Something protective moved through him.

For once, Darren had information he did not want to sell, trade, explain or accidentally give away.

That felt new.

SATURDAY 19 OCTOBER 2019 - THE OTHER VISIT

CONNOR

Two and a half weeks had passed since Kez first made it sound exciting.

That had been the clever part.

Not rushing him.

Letting prison administration do the waiting for him.

The woman had to be added to Connor's visiting arrangements. Forms went in. Days passed. Connor worked on the wing, argued with Jamo, spoke to home, got used to being called Rush and occasionally managed to convince himself the whole thing might never happen.

Then Thursday Kez had said one word.

Saturday.

Now Connor was waiting to be called for a visit with a woman he had never met.

He still did not know what he was being paid.

Somehow that fact had only started bothering him properly that morning.

Kez had said money.

Kez had said reputation.

Kez had said people would know Connor was reliable.

Connor had supplied the rest himself.

That was what irritated him most.

Jamo watched him get ready without saying much.

At the door he finally said:

"Still doing it then?"

Connor looked back.

"Yeah."

"Know what you're getting?"

Connor hesitated.

Jamo's face changed.

"You don't, do you?"

"I'll get sorted."

Jamo stared at him.

Connor immediately hated the sentence because it sounded exactly like Kez.

"Right," Jamo said.

"What?"

"Nothing."

"Say it."

Jamo shook his head.

"Go on your visit, mate."

Connor left before the conversation could become useful.

The woman was older than Connor expected.

Not old.

Just normal.

Normal coat. Normal hair. Tired face.

That somehow made the whole thing stranger.

She smiled when she saw him, but there was no recognition in it.

Connor sat down opposite her.

"All right?"

"Yeah. You Connor?"

That was nearly funny.

"Yeah."

"Right."

Then they had to behave like two people who had a reason to be sitting together.

The first few minutes were agony.

Weather.

Traffic.

A vague reference to somebody Connor recognised by name.

Neither of them was convincing enough for Connor to stop feeling watched.

Every officer seemed too close.

Every pause felt suspicious.

Connor wondered what the woman had been told about him.

Probably not much.

Maybe only a name.

That thought made him feel smaller inside the arrangement.

Kez had spent two weeks making Connor feel selected.

Sitting opposite the stranger, Connor felt replaceable.

Eventually the moment came.

The woman passed responsibility for a prohibited parcel to Connor.

No ceremony.

No feeling of power.

Just the sudden knowledge that the dangerous part now belonged to him.

The rest of the visit became difficult to follow.

The woman kept talking.

Connor answered.

He could not have repeated half of what either of them said afterwards.

He was thinking about the search waiting after the visit and about the fact that nobody

who had praised him into doing this would be standing beside him if things went wrong.

When the visit ended, Connor felt briefly sick.

He followed the normal post-visit process, which included a strip search.

He had known that beforehand.

Knowing it in a cell and standing through it were completely different things.

For those minutes there was no Rush.

No reputation.

No Kez telling him he was building a name.

Just Connor Blake, twenty-one years old, frightened that a decision made weeks earlier was about to cost him badly.

It did not.

He got back through the process without the prohibited parcel being detected.

The exact physical mechanics were not what stayed with him afterwards.

What stayed with him was fear.

Relief came first.

Then pride.

He had done it.

That pride lasted until Kez told him what he had actually done it for.

KEZ

Kez found Connor not long after he was back.

"All good?"

Connor nodded.

"Yeah."

Kez smiled.

"Knew you would be."

Connor waited.

Kez lowered his voice and explained the split.

Connor stared at him.

"That's mine?"

"Yeah."

"And that's yours?"

"Yeah."

Connor looked at the difference again.

It worked out at roughly one part to Connor for every four Kez kept.

Connor's face changed.

"You're taking the piss."

Kez frowned as if Connor had become difficult without warning.

"What?"

"I did the visit."

"And you're getting paid."

"You never said that's what the split was."

Kez shrugged.

"You never asked."

That sentence did it.

Connor stepped closer.

"Don't do that."

"Do what?"

"Talk to me like I'm some fucking kid you've just sent running around for you."

Kez's expression hardened slightly.

"Then don't act like one."

For a second Connor genuinely wanted to hit him.

Not because of the money alone.

Because the whole two weeks rearranged itself in his head.

Switched on.

Make a name.

People will trust you.

Kez had not lied exactly.

That almost made it worse.

He had simply let Connor hear whatever Connor most wanted to hear.

Connor's hands tightened.

Kez noticed.

"You gonna do something stupid now as well?"

Connor stared at him.

That was another trap and, for once, Connor could see it before stepping into it.

Only just.

He started to turn away.

Kez sighed.

"All right."

Connor stopped.

"What?"

"I'll move it a bit. You get a quarter."

Connor looked back at him.

"A quarter?"

"Yeah. That's me moving. Don't take the piss."

Connor laughed once without humour.

"I'm taking the piss?"

Kez's voice stayed level.

"You think everything left over is just mine to stick in my pocket? I've got costs in it. The pack doesn't appear for free. Other people have got their bit before you even see yours."

Connor did not know how much of that was true.

That was part of the problem.

He had agreed to something without knowing enough to tell the difference.

"Should've told me before."

"Should've asked before."

Connor stared at him.

Kez stared back.

Neither apologised.

The extra bit did not make Connor feel grateful.

If anything, it made the whole thing clearer: Kez could move when Connor pushed back. He simply had not intended to until Connor made it uncomfortable not to.

Connor walked away still furious, but no longer quite close enough to fury to do something stupid.

Behind him Kez said:

"You'll calm down when you've got your bit."

Connor kept walking.

JAMO

Jamo knew something had changed the second Connor entered the cell.

Not fear this time.

Anger.

"How'd it go?"

Connor sat down hard.

"Kez is a prick."

Jamo waited.

Connor told him about the split and the small increase after the argument.

Jamo stared for a second.

Then, against his better judgement, laughed.

Connor looked at him.

"What's funny?"

"Nothing."

"You're laughing."

"I'm trying not to."

"Jamo."

Jamo covered his mouth.

"Sorry. It's just-mate. You didn't ask?"

Connor's face darkened.

"He said I'd make money."

"You did."

"That's not the point."

Jamo stopped laughing.

The phrase hung between them.

Then Jamo smiled.

"Oh, now you like that sentence."

Connor tried to stay angry.

Failed for half a second.

Then the humiliation came back.

"I nearly hit him."

Jamo's smile disappeared.

"Don't."

"Why?"

"Because then he's mugged you off twice."

Connor looked at him.

Jamo pointed at the door.

"First he gets you to take his risk. Then he gets you nicked because you're angry about it. Brilliant business for him."

Connor hated that too.

Everyone was being sensible at him lately.

CONNOR - LATER

Craig did not ask how the visit went.

He looked at Connor once and said:

"What's Kez done?"

Connor stopped.

"How do you know it's Kez?"

Craig waited.

Connor sighed.

"He stitched me on the split."

Craig's face barely moved.

"Did he tell you the split before?"

"No."

"Did you ask?"

Connor glared at him.

"Don't start."

Craig almost smiled.

Connor told him enough.

Not the mechanics. Not the parcel itself.

Just the two weeks of being told he was building a name, the fear of the visit, the share Kez revealed afterwards and the small increase Connor got when he pushed back.

Craig listened.

"He moved from a fifth to a quarter?"

"Yeah. Like he was doing me a favour."

Craig nodded.

"Maybe he was. A little one."

Connor looked at him sharply.

"Whose side are you on?"

"I'm not on a side."

Craig leaned back against the rail.

"Kez isn't keeping every bit you don't get. He's got costs attached to the pack and other people involved before it ever reaches you. That part might be completely true."

Connor frowned.

"So twenty percent was fair?"

"Didn't say that."

Craig looked at him.

"The problem isn't only the number. The problem is you agreed without knowing the number. You took the biggest immediate risk and let somebody else decide afterwards what that was worth."

Connor said nothing.

Craig continued.

"And when you got angry, he moved a little because he didn't want a scene. Fine. Learn from that as well. People move when it suits them."

Connor looked away.

"Still feels like he mugged me off."

"Probably did."

Connor looked back.

Craig smiled faintly.

"Two things can be true. He can have genuine costs and still have seen you coming."

That landed harder than Connor expected.

Craig let the silence sit for a moment.

Then said:

"Useful isn't the same as important, Connor."

Connor looked away again.

"I know."

"Do you?"

"I do now."

"Good."

Connor frowned.

"That's it?"

"What do you want me to say?"

"I dunno."

Craig looked toward the wing.

"He found something you wanted to hear and kept saying it until you volunteered."

Connor said nothing.

"That's not power," Craig said. "That's somebody else knowing which button to press."

Connor thought about hitting Kez again.

Craig seemed to read enough from his face.

"And if you lose your head now, he presses it twice."

Connor looked at him.

Craig walked away.

No threat against Kez.

No offer to fix it.

That annoyed Connor at first.

Later, he understood that was part of the lesson too.

BRUCE

Bruce was sitting with Yusuf when Connor walked past.

He looked at Connor once.

"You've got bad-business face."

Connor stopped.

Yusuf closed his eyes.

"Bruce."

"What?"

Connor stared at him.

"What's bad-business face?"

Bruce shrugged.

"Like successful-crime face but with accounting problems."

Yusuf started laughing.

Connor tried not to.

Failed.

Bruce pointed at him.

"There. That's the exact tax bracket."

Connor shook his head and walked away.

Yusuf looked at Bruce.

"How do you keep doing that?"

Bruce opened a packet of biscuits.

"Pattern recognition and no social brakes."

SUNDAY 20 OCTOBER 2019 - OUTSIDE

CONNOR

Connor had begun measuring calls by what people did not tell him.

His mum told him everyone was fine.

Which meant somebody wasn't.

His sister was "being herself."

Which meant she had argued with somebody.

His little brother was "good, just missing you."

That one needed no translation.

Connor stood at the wing phone with one hand cupped around the receiver even though everybody nearby could still hear half the conversation.

"Put him on."

His mum hesitated.

"He's playing."

"Mum."

"I'll get him."

Connor waited.

The wing continued around him.

A cleaner trolley rattled somewhere.

Someone argued about laundry.

Bruce shouted that he'd found "the world's most suspicious yoghurt."

Then his little brother came on.

"Connor?"

Connor smiled immediately.

"All right, mate?"

"When you coming home?"

There it was.

No hello proper.

No warm-up.

Children were efficient with pain.

"I don't know yet."

"Mum said court."

"Yeah. Got court stuff."

"Are you in prison?"

Connor looked at the wall.

His mum had obviously tried to soften it.

"Yeah."

Silence.

"Is it scary?"

Connor almost laughed.

Not because it was funny.

Because nobody inside had asked him that plainly.

"Nah. Boring mostly."

Another lie.

Smaller than some.

"Do you get PlayStation?"

Connor smiled.

"No."

"That's dead."

"Exactly."

His brother moved on to school, football and a game Connor had never heard of.

Connor listened carefully.

For five minutes he was not Rush.

Not Craig's young mate.

Not an aggravated-burglary defendant.

Just an older brother trying to sound present from a building he could not leave.

When the call ended, he stayed holding the receiver for a second after the line went dead.

MACCA

Macca had learned not to ask Connor how home was immediately after a call.

You could see the answer.

Instead he handed him a tea.

Connor looked at it.

"What's this?"

"Tea."

"Why?"

"Because I'm poisoning you slowly. What do you think?"

Connor took it.

They leaned near the rail.

"Kid brother?" Macca asked eventually.

Connor nodded.

"Asked when I'm home."

Macca looked out over the wing.

"Kids always ask the question adults learn not to."

Connor sipped the tea.

"You miss yours?"

Macca laughed quietly.

"Only every minute I'm awake."

Connor looked at him.

Macca shrugged.

"That's the sentence they don't put on the warrant."

Connor stored the line away without saying anything.

CONNOR - GIRLFRIEND

His girlfriend called later through an arranged time at home.

She sounded distracted.

Connor noticed immediately.

"What you doing?"

"Nothing."

There was music behind her.

"Where are you?"

"At Chloe's."

"Who's there?"

A pause.

Tiny.

Connor still heard it.

"Just people."

"What people?"

"Connor, don't start."

He felt the familiar outside-world
helplessness tighten in his chest.

If he had been home, he could have driven
over.

Could have seen for himself.

Could have turned uncertainty into something
concrete.

In prison, suspicion had nowhere to go.

"I'm not starting. I'm asking."

"And I'm answering."

"Not really."

She sighed.

That sigh irritated him more than any actual
answer.

"I can't sit indoors every night because you're
in there."

Connor went quiet.

The sentence was reasonable.

That made it hurt more.

"Didn't say you had to."

"Sounds like you are."

Connor looked at the men waiting for phones behind him.

"Forget it."

"Connor-"

"I've got to go."

He did not.

But prison gave him an excuse normal relationships did not.

He ended the call early.

Then immediately wanted to ring back.

He couldn't.

Someone else needed the phone.

YUSUF

Yusuf found Connor sitting quiet later.

"Relationship?"

Connor looked at him.

"How does everyone know everything?"

"You lot all make the same face."

"Jamo says I've got faces."

"You do. Very expressive eyebrows."

Connor laughed reluctantly.

Yusuf sat beside him.

"She doing your head in?"

"Just going out."

"Terrible crime."

Connor looked over.

Yusuf smiled.

"You want me to tell you she's definitely faithful because you're in prison?"

Connor said nothing.

"Or definitely cheating because you're in prison?"

Still nothing.

"I can do either. Charge is one coffee."

Connor smiled.

"You're useless."

"No. I'm honest. More expensive service."

Connor stared across the wing.

"Feels weird. Everyone out there just carries on."

Yusuf nodded.

"That's because they do."

"Helpful again."

"You lot keep asking questions with annoying answers."

Connor thought about his little brother growing, his mum worrying, his girlfriend at Chloe's, and himself pushing a mop around C Wing under a name Bruce invented.

Prison had stopped his movement.

It had not stopped anyone else's.

BRUCE

The yoghurt was eventually cleared of suspicion.

"What was suspicious about it?" Josh asked.

Bruce looked at him as though the answer were obvious.

"Date was too confident."

Josh laughed.

"What does that mean?"

"Best before Tuesday. It's Sunday. That's arrogance."

Josh laughed harder.

Darren shook his head.

"Don't listen to him."

Josh pointed at Bruce.

"I like him."

Bruce nodded solemnly.

"Strong instincts. Weak future."

Darren looked at him.

"That's dark."

"I meant because he likes me. Keep up."

Josh was still laughing.

Connor heard it from farther down the wing.

He looked over.

For a moment the sound pulled him out of his own head.

That was one of the strange mercies of prison.

Somebody else's stupid joke could interrupt your worst thought simply because there was nowhere else for either of you to go.

TUESDAY 22 OCTOBER 2019 - TYLER

CONNOR - C WING

Connor recognised the new-boy walk now.

It was not one walk exactly.

Some men came onto the wing trying to disappear.

Some stared at everything.

Some looked at the floor.

Tyler walked in like he had been invited.

"Yeah, I know this type of place," he said to nobody who had asked.

Connor looked over from the cleaning trolley.

Jamo appeared beside him.

"Fresh one."

"Can tell."

"How?"

Connor nodded toward Tyler.

"He's telling everyone he isn't."

Jamo smiled.

Tyler was carrying his property and speaking to an officer at the same time.

"My cousin knows bare people in here anyway. I'll be sweet."

The officer looked at him without interest.

"Cell's that way."

"Yeah, yeah. I know."

He immediately went the wrong direction.

Connor put his head down to hide the laugh.

TYLER

Tyler had been frightened since the van.

He had decided not to tell anybody.

That decision had expanded into a full personality by the time he reached C Wing.

He knew people.

He had done things.

He was used to trouble.

His cousin was known.

He had mates in three different towns.

Prison did not bother him.

None of those sentences changed the fact his hands had been shaking in reception.

He had solved that by keeping them in his pockets.

Now a ginger bloke was looking at him.

"What?" Tyler said.

The ginger bloke shrugged.

"Nothing."

"Why you staring then?"

"Trying to work out if your confidence is factory fitted or aftermarket."

Tyler frowned.

"What?"

The ginger bloke walked away.

Tyler looked at Connor.

"Who's that?"

"Bruce."

"He weird?"

Connor considered it.

"Yes. But don't mistake that for harmless."

Tyler nodded as though he already knew.

"Yeah, I've met loads like him."

Connor smiled.

Of course he had.

JAMO

Jamo did what somebody had done for him six months earlier.

He explained the basics.

Not everything.

Nobody could.

Where to ask about applications.

When gym lists usually went up.

How canteen worked in broad terms.

Who not to interrupt on the phone.

That last one earned a look from Macca.

Tyler nodded through all of it too quickly.

"Yeah, yeah, I know."

Jamo stopped.

"You know?"

"My cousin's done time. Told me all this."

"Right."

"He knows people here too."

Jamo looked at Connor.

Connor looked away because if they made eye contact they would laugh.

"What's your cousin called?" Jamo asked.

Tyler hesitated for less than a second.

"Dre."

"Dre what?"

"Just Dre."

Jamo nodded solemnly.

"Of course."

Tyler did not hear the joke.

Not yet.

JOSH

Josh loved Tyler immediately for the worst possible reason.

Tyler was new enough that Josh was no longer the newest.

"Bro, I'll show you where everything is."

Darren looked over.

"You've been here eight days."

Josh ignored him.

"Gym's down there-"

"No it isn't," Darren said.

Josh stopped.

"I knew that."

Tyler laughed.

"You lot are jokes."

Josh pointed to Connor.

"That's Rush."

Connor closed his eyes.

"Don't."

Tyler looked impressed.

"Why they call you Rush?"

Josh took a breath.

Connor pointed at him.

"If you tell the story, I'll drown you in the mop bucket."

Josh grinned.

"He saved Craig."

Connor groaned.

"Didn't save anyone."

Tyler's face changed.

"Craig Craig?"

Connor looked at him.

"What does that mean?"

"You know. Craig."

"Clearly not."

Tyler nodded as if Connor had confirmed something.

"My cousin knows people around him."

Jamo coughed into his hand.

Connor looked at the ceiling.

Josh believed him instantly.

"Serious?"

"Yeah."

Tyler stood a little taller.

The lie had found its first customer.

TYLER - PHONE

That evening Tyler got through to his mum.

His voice changed immediately.

Not completely.

Enough.

"Yeah, Mum, I'm fine."

He leaned against the wall, keeping his back to the wing.

"No, it's calm."

His mum said something long enough that Tyler rolled his eyes even though she could not see.

"I'm eating."

Pause.

"Yes, Mum."

Pause.

"I don't know where the toothpaste is yet."

A louder voice from the phone.

"All right! I'll ask."

Connor happened to walk past.

Tyler lowered his voice.

"No one's bothering me. It's easy."

Connor kept walking.

The word easy caught him.

He remembered his own first call.

Same lie.

Different delivery.

Tyler ended the call.

He stood still for a second with his forehead almost touching the wall.

Then he turned around.

Connor was nearby.

Tyler's posture changed instantly.

"Mums, innit. Always stressing."

Connor nodded.

"Yeah."

Tyler looked relieved that Connor did not say more.

"She calls me Ty. Hate that."

"Why?"

"Makes me sound twelve."

Connor smiled.

"Probably why she does it."

Tyler smiled back.

For about three seconds the performance dropped.

Then someone walked past.

Tyler's shoulders came back up.

"Anyway, this place is calm."

Connor nodded.

"Course it is."

He left Tyler with the lie.

Some lies needed time before they could be removed safely.

BRUCE

Bruce found Jamo later.

"New one's lying."

Jamo looked at him.

"About what?"

"Everything between his shoes and hairline."

"That's most of him."

"Exactly."

Jamo laughed.

"Leave him alone. He's scared."

Bruce looked genuinely surprised.

"I know."

Jamo studied him.

"Then why take the piss?"

Bruce thought.

"Because fear hates being looked at directly."

Jamo stared at him.

Bruce frowned.

"That sounded too sensible. Forget I said it."

He walked away.

Jamo watched him go.

Bruce's entire personality sometimes felt like a disguise nobody had asked him to wear.

FRIDAY 25 OCTOBER 2019 - STORIES

MALIK

Tyler had been in Lewes three days and already possessed a criminal history large enough to require an appendix.

According to Tyler:

- his cousin knew serious people in London;
- his mate's brother had once shared a wing with somebody famous;
- he had been chased by armed police twice;
- he could get "anything sorted" outside;
- and he definitely was not worried about his case.

Malik had heard all five claims by lunchtime.

He believed one and a half.

"Which half?" Yusuf asked.

"He knows a cousin."

Yusuf nodded.

"Strong evidence."

"The rest is performance."

"You planning to expose him?"

Malik looked offended.

"Why would I?"

Yusuf stared at him.

Malik sighed.

"Fine. Old me might've."

"Old you was Tuesday."

"People grow."

They watched Tyler talking to Josh.

Josh looked fascinated.

"That's the dangerous bit," Malik said.

"What?"

"Someone believing you."

Yusuf looked at him.

For once, Malik had said something without intending it to sound wise.

He decided not to ruin it.

TYLER

Tyler liked Josh because Josh believed everything enthusiastically.

Not stupidly.

Just generously.

If Tyler said he knew someone, Josh asked what they were like.

If Tyler said he'd been in a chase, Josh wanted the whole story.

If Tyler said his cousin could sort something, Josh said, "Serious?"

Each reaction made the next claim easier.

Darren was less impressed.

"Your cousin sounds busy," he said.

Tyler looked at him.

"What?"

"Knows everyone. Does everything. Surprised he's got time for family."

Josh laughed.

Tyler smiled too, but something in his face tightened.

"He does know people."

Darren raised both hands.

"Didn't say he didn't."

Tyler hated the sentence because it sounded exactly like Grant without Tyler knowing who Grant was.

He changed subject.

"When's gym list?"

Josh answered before Darren could.

This time, he got it right.

Darren gave him a proud look.

"Look at you. Institutionalised already."

Josh grinned.

Tyler laughed.

The fear went quiet for a while.

That was why he talked.

Silence gave it room.

OFFICER BENNETT

Bennett had started checking who was behind him when he left work.

He knew how ridiculous that was.

Knowing did not stop it.

The pressure from outside had not become dramatic.

That was what frightened him most.

No movie threats.

No men waiting beside his car.

Just messages.

Knowledge.

A reference to where his partner worked.

A mention of a debt he had thought nobody at work knew about.

And requests framed as if agreement had already happened.

Inside Lewes, Bennett remained Officer Bennett.

He unlocked doors.

Answered applications badly.

Broke up arguments about food.

Told men to get off the phones.

Outside, somebody else seemed to have a key to him.

Mercer caught him staring at his phone in the staff area.

"You all right?"

Bennett locked the screen.

"Yeah."

Mercer looked at him.

He smiled.

"What?"

"Nothing."

"Why's everyone saying nothing like it's something?"

Mercer almost laughed.

"You've been around prisoners too long."

Bennett put the phone away.

"Long week."

Mercer nodded.

She believed half of that.

The other half stayed with her.

OFFICER MERCER

Craig was easier to deal with when he was difficult.

That was the problem Mercer had not expected.

If he had been constantly arrogant, threatening or demanding, she could have put him in a category and kept him there.

Instead he was polite when he chose to be.

Funny occasionally.

Observant without making a show of it.

He remembered staff names.

He asked a junior officer whether she'd recovered from a cold three days after she mentioned it once.

That sort of thing was dangerous in a different way.

It created the illusion that the relationship was personal because the interaction was personal.

Mercer knew better.

Knowing better was not the same as feeling nothing.

She found Craig waiting near a door during movement.

"Mercer."

"Craig."

"You look tired."

"Thank you."

"Wasn't an insult."

"Still not useful."

He smiled faintly.

"Bennett all right?"

Mercer looked at him.

"Why?"

Craig shrugged.

"Seems distracted."

That was all.

No accusation.

No explanation.

Mercer felt a small coldness move through her.

She had noticed it too.

The fact Craig had noticed bothered her more.

"Worry about yourself," she said.

"Usually do."

He moved on.

Mercer watched him go, annoyed that two separate concerns had just become one conversation.

CONNOR

Connor's own story had grown without his permission.

Someone on another landing apparently believed he and Craig knew each other outside.

Someone else thought Connor had been moved to Lewes specifically because Craig wanted him there.

That one was so ridiculous Connor laughed for a full minute.

Then he realised part of him liked it.

He was cleaning near the rail when Craig passed.

"Apparently you arranged my remand," Connor said.

Craig stopped.

"Did I?"

"Yeah. Powerful man."

"Clearly."

"Could've arranged a better job."

Craig looked at the mop.

"Builds character."

"Fuck off."

Craig smiled and walked on.

Bruce appeared almost instantly.

"Was that your performance review?"

Connor looked at him.

"Do you sleep?"

"Between developments."

Connor shook his head.

Bruce looked down the landing where Tyler was talking loudly.

"New one's building a castle out of smoke."

Connor followed his gaze.

"Tyler?"

"Yeah."

"He's just scared."

Bruce nodded.

"So are most architects."

Connor frowned.

"That makes no sense."

"Give it a week."

DARREN

Grant wanted another small thing.

This time Darren recognised the pattern before answering.

"No."

Grant looked at him.

"I haven't asked yet."

"Doesn't matter."

"Interesting."

Darren shifted in the chair.

"I'm done talking about people."

Grant's expression stayed calm.

"You think you've been talking about people?"

Darren stared at him.

There it was again.

The soft denial that somehow made the thing more real.

"I said I'm done."

Grant leaned back.

"Fine."

Darren waited.

That was too easy.

"Fine?"

"Fine."

Darren stood.

Grant looked down at paperwork.

Darren reached the door.

"How's the new lad settling?"

Darren stopped.

He turned slowly.

Grant was still reading.

Josh.

The question was ordinary.

Darren heard leverage in it anyway.

"He's fine."

"Good."

Darren left.

On the wing Josh was laughing so hard at something Bruce had said that he had to lean against the wall.

Darren looked at him.

For the first time, Grant's pressure felt like it had moved close to somebody Darren cared about.

That changed the shape of it.

MONDAY 28 OCTOBER 2019 - KNOCKED BACK

JAMO

The visits-orderly job went to somebody else.

That was the sentence.

Everything around it was administration.

His application remained on file.

He could be considered for future vacancies.

There had been several candidates.

Operational requirements.

Security considerations.

Thank you for your interest.

Jamo sat in education afterwards and read the same paragraph four times without taking in a word.

Six months.

He had done exactly what people told him to do.

Education.

No fights.

No stupid debts.

No drugs.

No pointless nickings.

He had imagined the job before it existed.

Being out of the cell more.

Seeing different faces.

Having somewhere to be.

Being trusted.

Then Connor arrived.

Jamo knew that was not a fair equation.

He knew Connor had not selected the other candidate.

Had not ordered the search.

Had not written the words security considerations.

Knowing all of that did absolutely nothing to stop resentment choosing Connor's face.

CONNOR

Connor knew before Jamo told him.

Not the details.

The walk.

Jamo came onto the wing carrying his papers too carefully.

"Didn't get it?"

Jamo looked at him.

Connor regretted asking immediately.

"No."

"Shit."

"Yeah."

Connor put down the cloth he was using.

"Did they say why?"

"Other candidate. Security. Whatever."

Connor nodded.

Jamo hated the nod.

"Don't."

Connor frowned.

"Don't what?"

"Do the sympathy face."

"I'm not doing a face."

"Everyone in this prison has apparently become an expert on faces."

Connor felt his own irritation rise.

"What do you want me to say?"

Jamo laughed.

"Nothing."

"There it is again."

"What?"

"You saying nothing when you mean me."

Jamo looked at him.

"Fine. You want me to say it?"

Connor held his gaze.

"Go on."

"I think all the shit around you has made me look like a security problem when I wasn't one before."

Connor's jaw tightened.

"There. Happy?"

"No, because that's bollocks."

"Is it?"

"Yeah."

"We got spun after your visit thing."

"You don't know that."

"We got association concerns after you became Craig's little mate."

That phrase changed the temperature.

Connor stepped closer.

"Don't call me that."

Jamo immediately knew where he had hit.

"Why? That's what everyone else thinks."

"I'm not anyone's little mate."

"Exactly. You're Rush now, aren't you?"

Silence.

Connor stared at him.

Jamo stared back.

Then Josh wandered around the corner holding two sachets of coffee.

"Daz said-"

He stopped.

Looked between them.

"Bad time?"

Neither answered.

Josh backed away.

"Yep. Bad time."

The interruption saved them from saying something worse.

For the moment.

MASON

Mason found Jamo alone later.

"You get the job?"

Jamo looked at him.

Mason read the answer.

"No."

"No."

Mason sat nearby.

He did not say everything happened for a reason.

Prison cured people of that phrase quickly.

Sometimes things happened because somebody lost paperwork.

Sometimes because a manager made a decision.

Sometimes because another prisoner did something stupid three doors away.

Sometimes for no reason anybody could explain.

"I did everything right," Jamo said.

Mason nodded.

"I know."

"So what's the point?"

"Dangerous question."

Jamo looked at him.

"Why?"

"Because if you decide doing right only matters when you get rewarded, one bad decision from staff can choose the rest of your sentence for you."

Jamo looked away.

"Easy for you to say."

Mason smiled faintly.

"I've made that mistake about forty times. That's why it's easy to say now."

Jamo laughed despite himself.

"Connor thinks I'm blaming him."

"Are you?"

Jamo was quiet.

"Bit."

"Fairly?"

Longer silence.

"Bit."

Mason nodded.

"Honest, at least."

DARREN AND JOSH

Josh had decided he could cook.

This was news to Darren.

"You can't even make your bed."

"Different skill."

"You tried to microwave something with a wrapper on yesterday."

"Nearly."

"That word is doing heroic work."

Josh grinned.

A prisoner farther along, known for putting together better food than most people managed, was helping a couple of men sort an evening meal from ordinary canteen and servery bits.

Josh watched with fascination.

"That's sick."

Darren looked over.

"It's dinner."

"No, but proper dinner."

"Your standards have collapsed in two weeks."

"Adaptation."

Darren laughed.

Josh had learned that word from Leon and now used it for everything.

Bad tea? Adaptation.

Broken TV? Adaptation.

Being locked behind a door? Adaptation.

Darren liked him more every day.

That frightened Darren slightly.

People were easier when you did not care what happened to them.

Josh looked over.

"You all right, Daz?"

"Yeah."

"You went quiet."

"Thinking."

Josh looked alarmed.

"You?"

Darren shoved him lightly with his shoulder.

Josh laughed.

For now, Darren was still the good thing in Josh's prison life.

Neither of them knew how complicated that would become.

JINX - A WING

Jinx and Deano had reached an arrangement neither would call an arrangement.

If either heard something that looked likely to drag their friends into the Craig fallout, they would tell the other enough to stop stupidity spreading.

Not intelligence sharing.

Not alliance.

Definitely not friendship.

"This is temporary," Deano said.

Jinx smiled.

"You worried I'll invite you to my birthday?"

"Massively."

"Relax. Dress code would finish you."

Deano looked at his prison clothes.

"We're wearing the same thing."

"And somehow you're still doing it worse."

Deano laughed.

That was prison too.

Groups people outside imagined as permanent enemies could spend Monday afternoon taking the piss out of each other's clothes because both wanted the same problem to stay somewhere else.

Then the phone rang somewhere and both men remembered why they were talking.

OFFICER MERCER

Mercer saw Bennett make another mistake.

Small.

He forgot to log something he normally logged automatically, corrected himself

immediately and became defensive before anyone accused him.

"You need a day off," Mercer said.

"I'm fine."

"You're doing the prisoner answer now."

Bennett smiled weakly.

"What answer?"

"Fine."

"I am."

Mercer watched him.

Craig's earlier comment returned.

Bennett all right?

She disliked that Craig had seen it.

She disliked more that he might have seen it before she did.

"If something's going on-"

"Nothing's going on."

Too fast.

Mercer stopped.

Bennett looked away.

There was a line between noticing and accusing.

She did not cross it.

Not yet.

CONNOR - NIGHT

Connor and Jamo barely spoke after bang-up.

The TV worked perfectly.

For once, Connor wished it didn't.

A broken signal might have forced them to laugh.

Instead they watched something neither cared about.

Connor looked down from the top bunk.

"I am sorry you didn't get it."

Jamo kept his eyes on the screen.

"I know."

"And I didn't mean to mess anything up for you."

"I know."

Connor waited.

"Still pissed at me?"

Jamo sighed.

"Yeah."

Connor nodded.

"Fair."

Jamo looked up.

"Don't do that either."

"What?"

"Be reasonable. Makes it harder."

Connor smiled.

Jamo almost did.

Almost was doing a lot of work in their cell lately.

THURSDAY 31 OCTOBER 2019 - ONE MONTH IN

CONNOR - C WING

By the end of October, Connor knew which bit of the landing stayed damp longest after he mopped it.

That felt like the sort of knowledge nobody should ever be proud of.

He was proud of it anyway.

"You've missed a bit," Bruce said.

Connor did not turn around.

"No I haven't."

"You don't even know where I'm pointing."

"Because you're always lying."

"Harsh."

Connor looked back.

Bruce was not pointing anywhere.

"See?"

"I could've been."

"But you weren't."

"Potential matters."

Connor pushed the trolley on.

One month.

Not even that, technically.

Forty-one days ago he had been at home thinking the burglary was behind him.

Now he had a prison job, a prison nickname, a prison cellmate he was arguing with, a man like Craig calling him by his real name and a growing list of people who believed they knew what sort of person Rush was.

Connor still did not know.

That was the strange bit.

Other people seemed to be deciding faster than him.

JAMO

Jamo had stopped mentioning visits orderly.

That was how Connor knew he was still thinking about it.

Before the knock-back, Jamo had talked about the job constantly.

Afterwards, nothing.

He still went to education.

Still filled forms.

Still kept his routine.

But something had changed in the cell.

Not enough to call the friendship broken.

Enough that silence no longer always meant comfort.

Jamo watched Connor coming and going more often.

Craig.

Malik.

Kez sometimes, although Connor kept more distance now.

People calling for Rush from the landing.

The cell had started feeling less like a place both of them lived and more like somewhere Connor's new life kept passing through.

Jamo hated that thought.

He hated more that part of it was jealousy.

He had no intention of admitting either yet.

JOSH

Josh had learned enough prison routine to become dangerous with confidence.

"Gym list's tomorrow."

Darren looked at him.

"Correct."

"Canteen Tuesday."

"Correct."

"Macca phone rule."

"Very correct."

"Bruce is mental."

Bruce, passing behind them, said:

"Subjective."

Josh laughed.

"And Rush is actually Connor but everyone calls him Rush because he rushed into Craig's fight."

Connor called from farther down:

"I can hear you!"

Josh shouted back:

"I'm educating people!"

"Educate quieter!"

Darren shook his head.

"You've settled in too fast."

Josh grinned.

"Told you. Adaptation."

"Stop saying that."

"Adaptation."

Darren tried not to laugh.

Failed.

Josh had started following him to meals, association, anything Darren was doing that allowed company.

The attachment had become ordinary enough that nobody commented anymore.

That was exactly how strong habits formed in prison.

Quietly.

Through repetition.

TYLER

Tyler's cousin had become more powerful with every retelling.

The problem arrived when somebody believed him in a useful way.

A prisoner Tyler barely knew came over during association.

"You said your cousin knows people in Croydon, yeah?"

Tyler's stomach dropped.

His face did not.

"Yeah. Why?"

"Might need a message passed outside. Nothing major."

Tyler heard the words nothing major and immediately thought of Connor saying prison favours were never described accurately by the person asking.

He had heard enough of Connor's visit story by now to understand the shape without knowing the details.

"Yeah, probably," Tyler said.

The prisoner nodded.

"I'll catch you tomorrow."

He walked away.

Tyler stood still.

Josh appeared beside him.

"What's he want?"

"Nothing."

"You look weird."

"I'm fine."

Josh accepted it.

Tyler looked across the wing for Connor.

Connor was talking to Craig.

Tyler considered going over.

Then he imagined explaining that he had invented a cousin's influence until somebody wanted to use it.

He stayed where he was.

The character Tyler had created had just been given homework.

DARREN

Grant called Darren again.

Darren ignored the first call.

Not pretending not to hear.

Actually ignored it.

Grant called again.

"Darren. Office."

Josh looked over.

Darren forced a smile.

"See you in a bit."

Inside the office Grant closed the door.

"You're getting brave."

Darren sat down.

"I'm getting bored."

"Of what?"

"This."

Grant nodded.

"Fine. Then give me something useful and we can both stop wasting time."

Darren looked at him.

There was the first time Grant had said it that plainly.

Something useful.

Not a chat.

Not observation.

Not helping keep order.

Information.

Darren felt sick.

"No."

Grant's face remained calm.

"No?"

"No."

Grant leaned back.

"You sure?"

Darren thought about Josh outside the office, probably talking to three people at once.

"Yeah."

Grant studied him.

"All right."

Again, too easy.

Darren stood.

At the door Grant said:

"People don't suddenly grow principles, Darren. They usually grow reasons."

Darren turned.

Grant's eyes flicked briefly toward the wing.

Toward where Josh was.

Maybe Darren imagined it.

Maybe he didn't.

"Leave him out of it," Darren said.

Grant's expression did not change.

"Leave who out of what?"

Darren stared at him.

Then walked out.

Grant had not threatened Josh.

That was exactly why Darren could not stop thinking that he had.

OFFICER MERCER

Mercer had begun noticing Craig when she was not looking for him.

That was the first boundary she did not know how to record.

Nothing improper had happened.

No secret meeting.

No favour.

No rule broken.

Just attention.

She knew when Craig had court because the wing felt slightly different without him.

She knew when he was in a good mood because Connor tended to be in one afterwards.

She knew which staff he respected and which he merely tolerated.

And now she had begun taking those observations home.

That was the problem.

Bennett walked past her in the staff area looking pale.

"You all right?"

"Yep."

Mercer almost laughed.

"We're banning that answer."

"What?"

"Fine. Yeah. All right. Any version of it."

Bennett managed a tired smile.

"Then no comment."

Mercer stopped smiling.

Something was wrong.

She knew it now.

She simply did not know what.

Craig had noticed too.

That fact stayed in her mind longer than it should have.

JINX - A WING

Jinx ended October more tired of other people's politics than he had started it.

The money around Craig had not disappeared after the failed attack.

It had changed form.

Less noise.

More resentment.

More people pretending they had never been interested.

Rico's name still caused conversations to stop or restart depending on who entered the room.

Deano had become the strangest useful contact Jinx had.

"Anything?" Deano asked.

"Nothing useful."

Deano nodded.

Jinx smiled.

"Look at us."

"What?"

"Old married couple."

"Fuck off."

"You asked how my day was."

"I asked if anybody was planning trouble."

"Intimacy starts somewhere."

Deano laughed despite himself.

Neither man trusted the wider situation.

They had started trusting each other just enough to dislike it.

MACCA

Macca got his daughter's birthday card drawing in the post twelve days late.

It was a picture of him standing beside a house, badly proportioned and smiling.

Above his head she had written:

DAD WHEN UR HOME

No punctuation.

Macca sat on his bunk looking at it for a long time.

He did not cry.

He came close enough that the distinction felt administrative.

Then he taped it beside the bed.

When Connor saw it later, he did not make a joke.

That was how Macca knew the lad was learning.

CONNOR - NIGHT

October ended without Connor noticing the exact moment.

There was no announcement.

No line crossed on the floor.

The doors shut at night like they had every other night.

Jamo was below him, quieter than he used to be.

Josh was shouting something through a wall until Darren told him to shut up.

Tyler was telling somebody he knew somebody.

Bruce was arguing with an officer about whether Halloween counted as a religious festival if you "believed strongly in ghosts."

Macca had his daughter's drawing on the wall.

Leon had gym in the morning.

Malik knew things.

Yusuf knew when not to care.

Darren was hiding more than anyone realised.

Bennett was carrying prison home.

Mercer was carrying Craig home in her thoughts without admitting it.

Craig was still an unanswered question walking around C Wing.

And Connor was Rush.

He lay on the top bunk looking at the ceiling.

A month ago he had been afraid of prison because he did not understand it.

Now he understood enough to feel comfortable in places that should probably have frightened him.

That felt like progress.

Mason would have called it something else.

Connor closed his eyes.

November waited on the other side of the door.